Cancel Culture: Why You May Not Know It’s an American Tradition — Part III: The Divide

Cancel culture is often debated as though the central question were whether people should be allowed to criticize, boycott, or condemn others for their words and actions. But that question only takes us so far. Americans have always used public pressure to challenge ideas, punish perceived wrongdoing, influence behavior, and fight over the boundaries of acceptable conduct. The more difficult question is what happens when that pressure moves beyond challenging an argument or demanding accountability and becomes an effort to deny others the right to participate in public life.

That question takes us beyond any single controversy, political party, or generation. It requires us to examine the relationship between disagreement and democracy, the ways political divisions deepen, and the point at which opponents stop being treated as fellow citizens and begin being treated as enemies. History offers examples of Americans managing profound disagreements through political institutions, as well as examples of what can happen when those institutions fail to contain them.

This is not an argument that every boycott is censorship, every protest is intimidation, or every effort to hold someone accountable is illegitimate. Nor is it an argument that every political movement deserves equal treatment regardless of its conduct or objectives. The distinction matters. A society must be able to challenge injustice without making disagreement itself grounds for exclusion. To understand where that line falls, we must first examine how a democracy is supposed to handle disagreement—and what happens when Americans begin to treat the existence of opposing views as a threat in itself.

Disagreement Is Not the Problem

There is a difference between saying, “You are wrong,” and saying, “You have no legitimate place in this country.” The first is disagreement. The second challenges the legitimacy of the person or group itself. That distinction may sound merely semantic until we consider what happens when political conflicts become so intense that the opposing side is no longer viewed as a group of fellow citizens who happen to hold different beliefs, but as an enemy whose existence threatens the survival of the nation. At that point, persuasion begins to give way to exclusion. The question changes from “How do I convince you?” to “How do I stop you?”

Consider how that shift can begin. Someone makes an argument. Someone else disagrees. The disagreement becomes organized opposition, and the opposition becomes economic or social pressure. A boycott may pressure a company to change its policies; a protest may pressure a government to respond; public criticism may persuade an institution to reconsider its decisions. Eventually, however, pressure can become an effort not merely to defeat an opposing argument, but to deny the people making it the ability to participate. The progression is not inevitable, and each step must be judged on its own merits, but it raises a question that sits at the heart of this essay: when does an attempt to influence others become an attempt to exclude them?

American history does not give us a simple answer, because collective pressure has been used for profoundly different purposes. The Civil Rights Movement deliberately employed boycotts, protests, sit-ins, and other forms of organized pressure to challenge a system that denied Black Americans equal

rights. Those actions were not merely requests for people in power to reconsider their decisions. They disrupted ordinary business, imposed economic costs, attracted public attention, and made it more difficult for institutions to ignore the injustice they were being asked to confront. The fact that the movement applied pressure did not make it illegitimate. When conventional political institutions failed to protect people's rights, collective action became one of the ways those people could exercise power. [Montgomery Bus Boycott] [National Park Service: Montgomery Bus Boycott] [NPS historical account]

But the same mechanisms can serve very different ends. A boycott can challenge discrimination, or it can seek to punish someone simply for belonging to the wrong political camp. A protest can demand reform, or it can become an effort to intimidate people into silence. Public criticism can expose wrongdoing, or it can turn into a campaign built on false information, exaggerated accusations, or demands for consequences wildly disproportionate to the conduct at issue. We cannot determine whether a campaign is justified simply by identifying the method it uses. Nor can we declare a campaign illegitimate simply because it makes someone uncomfortable or costs someone money. We have to examine the cause, the evidence, the conduct, the authority being exercised, and the consequences being demanded.

That is why the historical lesson is more complicated than declaring cancel culture either good or bad. Americans have always used collective pressure, and sometimes that pressure has expanded freedom while at other times it has restricted it. The same society that celebrates citizens organizing to challenge injustice can become suspicious of citizens organizing against a cause it supports. The same people who defend the right to boycott a business over one political position may condemn a boycott over another. The central question is not whether pressure should exist in public life. It is whether we can evaluate that pressure according to consistent principles, even when we dislike the people using it or the outcome they want.

The difficulty becomes greater when political disagreement starts to shape how we understand people outside politics. A dispute over taxes, immigration, gun laws, abortion, religion, or the role of government can begin as an argument about policy. But when political identity becomes deeply intertwined with social identity, that argument can start to feel like a judgment about who we are. Our political affiliations influence how we interpret our neighbors, coworkers, relatives, communities, and even ourselves. Instead of hearing a person express a position we believe is wrong, we begin to hear confirmation that the entire group to which that person belongs is dangerous, immoral, or beyond reason.

Political scientists have documented substantial partisan divisions in the United States, including stronger negative feelings toward the opposing party. The precise degree of polarization depends on what is being measured, and Americans do not all experience political conflict in the same way. Still, the broader concern is recognizable: when politics becomes a marker of personal and moral identity, compromise can begin to look less like negotiation and more like betrayal. If I disagree with you about a tax rate, we can debate the policy. If I believe your political worldview represents everything I fear about the country, your position on taxes may become evidence of something much larger about who you are. The argument is no longer confined to the issue before us.

And once compromise becomes betrayal, the political opponent becomes something more than an opponent. We stop saying, “I believe that policy is dangerous,” and begin saying, “Those people are dangerous.” We stop asking whether a particular argument is supported by evidence and begin treating the identity of the person making it as sufficient reason to dismiss it. That change may seem small, but it alters the purpose of political conflict. The opponent is no longer simply someone who needs to be persuaded, challenged, or defeated in a fair contest. The opponent becomes someone who needs to be stopped.

This is where polarization can develop into delegitimization. Delegitimization occurs when political opponents are treated not simply as people whose ideas should be challenged, but as people who have no legitimate claim to participate in the political system. Instead of saying, “I hope your party loses the election,” the argument becomes, “Your party should never have been allowed to win.” Instead of accepting that the other side represents a genuine portion of the electorate, people begin treating its supporters as inherently corrupt, dangerous, or outside the boundaries of acceptable citizenship.

There are legitimate reasons to challenge political leaders, institutions, and movements. Governments can act unlawfully, elections can be administered improperly, public officials can abuse their authority, and political movements can advocate policies that violate constitutional rights. Citizens must be able to expose those failures and demand change. The danger arises when the legitimacy of the opponent is challenged simply because the opponent is the opponent—when disagreement itself becomes evidence that a person or group has forfeited the right to participate.

A democracy cannot function if losing an argument means the other side has forfeited its right to take part in the next one. Elections, courts, legislatures, public debate, protest, and organizing all depend on some recognition that people can disagree deeply while remaining members of the same political community. We do not have to consider every argument wise, every movement admirable, or every political objective acceptable. We do have to distinguish between arguing that an opponent is wrong and claiming that the opponent has no legitimate place in public life.

The Election Problem

This becomes particularly important when elections are involved.

An election is not simply a contest over who gets power. It is also a mechanism through which political losers agree, at least in principle, to remain part of the same political system after the result is known. If I lose an election, I can challenge the result through lawful procedures. I can demand recounts where appropriate. I can litigate. I can investigate. I can organize for the next election.

What I cannot logically demand is that democracy continue only when my side wins.

That principle applies regardless of party.

The peaceful transfer of power is therefore more than a ceremonial tradition. It is an acknowledgment that political authority is temporary and that today's winner may be tomorrow's loser. When political actors begin treating legitimate defeat as proof that the system itself is illegitimate, the disagreement has moved into much more dangerous territory.

Researchers and scholars of democratic institutions have consequently treated acceptance of legitimate electoral defeat as an important component of democratic stability.

Dehumanization

Delegitimization can go one step further.

When political opponents are repeatedly described as existential threats, enemies, traitors, fascists, communists, invaders, terrorists, or other categories that place them outside the ordinary political community, the language of politics begins to resemble the language of war.

Again, context matters. Some political labels describe real ideologies or documented conduct. Calling a person a communist because they actually advocate communist policies is different from calling every political opponent a communist simply because you dislike them. Calling someone a fascist can be a substantive political argument in some circumstances, but it can also become a rhetorical insult that replaces evidence with a label.

The question is not whether Americans are ever allowed to use strong political language. Of course they are. The question is whether the language is being used to describe and challenge an opponent—or to convince people that the opponent is no longer entitled to the ordinary protections of political disagreement.

That distinction is enormously important.

Violence Is Not the Inevitable Next Step

It is also important not to turn this progression into a simplistic formula. Disagreement can become polarization, polarization can contribute to delegitimization, and delegitimization can contribute to dehumanization, but none of those steps makes political violence inevitable. Most Americans who are deeply polarized will never commit political violence. Most people who describe their political opponents in extreme terms will never physically attack anyone. Most protests remain peaceful, most boycotts remain economic rather than physical, and most political conflicts eventually return to elections, courts, legislation, or ordinary public argument.

That matters because political conflict is not inherently destructive. In a democracy, people are supposed to argue. They are supposed to organize against one another, criticize public officials, protest policies, boycott businesses, campaign against candidates, and try to persuade their neighbors that the other side is wrong. Some of those activities can become unpleasant, aggressive, or deeply divisive without becoming violent. The existence of intense political hostility does not by itself mean that a society is approaching physical conflict.

There is also a difference between rhetoric that is extreme and conduct that is violent. Americans have always used heated language in political disputes. Candidates have accused opponents of destroying the country. Protesters have described governments and institutions in morally absolute terms. Political movements have portrayed their opponents as threats to the future of the nation. That language can contribute to a more hostile political environment, particularly when it becomes constant or is used to deny the legitimacy of an entire group, but words alone do not tell us what someone will ultimately do.

At the same time, it would be a mistake to conclude that political violence is therefore imaginary or irrelevant. It is a real part of American political life, and Americans themselves increasingly recognize it as a problem. A 2025 Pew Research Center survey of 3,445 U.S. adults found that 85% said politically motivated violence in the United States was increasing. Republicans and Democrats expressed nearly identical views on that question. Respondents also identified partisan polarization, unwillingness to understand people with different views, acceptance of violence, and political rhetoric among factors contributing to the problem.[Pew Research Center (2025)] Source: Pew Research Center survey (2025) [Pew Research Center study]

Those are perceptions, not proof of a single cause. Pew's findings do not establish that polarization mechanically produces violence. They do not demonstrate that one political party, ideology, movement, or group is responsible for political violence in America. They do, however, demonstrate that Americans across the political spectrum increasingly perceive political violence as a serious problem and that many Americans themselves connect that problem with polarization, political rhetoric, and the inability or unwillingness to understand people with different views.

That distinction between perception and causation is important. If people believe political violence is becoming more common, that belief can affect how they view political opponents even when the underlying causes are more complicated. Fear changes political behavior. People who believe the other side is becoming increasingly dangerous may become less willing to listen, less willing to compromise, and more willing to support extraordinary measures against people they believe pose a threat. In that sense, the perception of political violence can itself become part of the political problem.

There is another reason violence deserves special attention. Peaceful political pressure assumes that the person on the other side remains capable of participating in the political process. A protester can demand that a law be changed. A voter can campaign against a candidate. A consumer can refuse to purchase a product. A political organization can try to defeat an opposing movement at the ballot box. All of those actions are forms of conflict, but they leave open the possibility that the disagreement can continue without physically destroying the people involved.

Violence changes that calculation. Once physical force becomes part of political conflict, participation itself can carry a physical cost. Candidates may be threatened. Public officials may fear for their safety. Journalists, activists, protesters, and ordinary citizens may decide that speaking publicly is no longer worth the risk. Even people who never experience violence personally can begin modifying their behavior because they believe that political disagreement has become dangerous.

This is why the distinction between disagreement, polarization, delegitimization, and violence matters. The progression we have been examining is not a conveyor belt. Americans can become intensely polarized and still maintain democratic institutions. They can use inflammatory language and still participate peacefully in elections. They can regard political opponents as profoundly misguided and still recognize their right to organize, vote, protest, speak, and participate in public life. The danger begins not because disagreement exists, but because the restraints that normally keep disagreement within political boundaries begin to weaken.

That should get our attention.

The question, then, is not whether every angry political argument will eventually become violent. It will not. The more important question is what happens when the political opponent is no longer understood simply as someone who is wrong, misguided, or even dangerous, but as someone who does not properly belong within the political community at all.

That is where the idea of the political enemy enters the discussion.

The Enemy Problem

The danger becomes greater once a political opponent is no longer understood simply as someone who is wrong, but as an enemy. An opponent can be someone whose arguments we reject, whose policies we believe would cause harm, or whose political goals we believe should be defeated. An enemy is something different: someone whose existence, influence, or participation begins to be understood as a threat that must be stopped. Once that distinction takes hold, ordinary political rules can begin to look optional.

If I believe you are simply wrong, I want to convince you. If I believe you are dangerous, I want to stop you. If I believe you are illegitimate, I want to prevent you from exercising political power. And if I believe you are an existential threat, almost anything can begin to look justified.

This is one of the most dangerous transformations in political conflict because it changes the purpose of political action. The objective is no longer simply to win an argument, defeat a candidate, change a law, or persuade voters. The objective becomes preventing the other side from exercising power at all. Once that happens, actions that would ordinarily seem unacceptable can begin to appear necessary because the person on the other side is no longer being judged as a fellow citizen with different political beliefs, but as a threat to be contained.

History provides plenty of examples of what can happen when political opponents are transformed into enemies. Americans have repeatedly used language that placed particular groups outside the boundaries of ordinary political disagreement, sometimes portraying them as traitors, subversives, threats to the social order, or enemies of the nation itself. The specific groups and accusations have changed across different periods, but the underlying logic is remarkably consistent: if the other side is not merely wrong but dangerous to the survival of the country, then defeating that side can begin to seem more important than preserving the rules by which political disagreement is normally managed.

That logic also helps explain why political violence is so destructive to democracy. Violence does not merely injure the immediate victim. It changes the political calculation for everyone watching. It tells people that disagreement may carry a physical price, and that participation in public life can make someone a target. Candidates may be intimidated. Public officials may fear retaliation. Journalists, activists, protesters, and ordinary citizens may become less willing to speak, organize, or participate because they believe political disagreement has become personally dangerous.

Recent research and analysis have documented threats and acts of political violence against public officials across ideological and partisan lines, while emphasizing that the causes are complex and cannot be reduced to one party or one movement. That complexity matters because political violence is particularly easy to turn into another weapon in the political argument. One side points to violence

committed by people associated with the other side and concludes that the other side is inherently dangerous. The other side responds by pointing to different examples and making the same accusation in return.

The answer, therefore, cannot simply be “the other side needs to stop.” Both sides can always find evidence that the other side is responsible for the problem. That does not mean every example is equally serious, every movement has behaved in the same way, or every claim about political violence is equally supported by evidence. It means that responsibility has to be examined case by case rather than assigned automatically according to political identity.

That is part of the problem.

Once political violence becomes another reason to hate the people on the other side, even violence itself can become absorbed into the same cycle that produced it. Instead of asking how political conflict reached the point where violence became possible, we ask only which political team should be blamed. Instead of trying to preserve the conditions under which citizens can disagree without becoming enemies, we use each new incident as evidence that our existing hostility toward the other side was justified.

And that brings us back to the mirror.

The Mirror

If you believe political violence is wrong when directed at your side, it has to be wrong when directed at the other side. If you believe political intimidation is unacceptable when your candidate receives it, it has to be unacceptable when your opponent receives it. If you believe political opponents deserve due process, constitutional rights, and the ability to participate in elections, those principles cannot disappear when the people involved hold views you consider repugnant.

This is where consistency becomes more difficult than simply identifying something we oppose. It is easy to condemn political intimidation when we are the ones being intimidated. It is easy to defend constitutional rights when those rights protect someone we admire. It becomes considerably harder when the person benefiting from the principle is someone whose politics we believe are harmful, offensive, or even dangerous. But that difficulty is precisely what makes the principle meaningful. If a right exists only for people whose opinions we approve of, it is not functioning as a right.

And if you believe your political opponents are so dangerous that extraordinary measures against them are justified, you have to ask what happens when the political power you are willing to give your side eventually belongs to theirs. The immediate temptation is to think only about the people holding power today. Democracy requires us to think about the people who may hold it tomorrow. A government authority, institutional power, or political weapon does not remain permanently in the hands of the people we trust. Eventually, political power changes hands.

That is not an argument for moral equivalence. There are real differences between political movements, real differences in policy, real differences in conduct, and real differences in the evidence surrounding particular claims. Some actions are more harmful than others, some claims are better supported than others, and some conduct can legitimately require consequences. Consistency does not mean

pretending those differences do not exist. It means that our basic principles should not change simply because we have changed the political identity of the person standing in front of us.

A democracy needs both abilities at the same time: the ability to distinguish between right and wrong and the ability to coexist with people who reach different conclusions. We have to be able to say that an argument is false, that a policy is harmful, that a person's conduct is unacceptable, or that a political movement should be defeated without concluding that everyone who belongs to that movement has therefore forfeited the ordinary rights of citizenship.

The mirror is uncomfortable precisely because it turns the question back toward us. We can ask what our political opponents are willing to do, but we also have to ask what we are willing to permit when our own side believes the cause is important enough. The test is not whether we can find a justification for using power against people we dislike. The test is whether we would still believe in the same rule if the people using that power were the people we feared most.

That is the difference between a political principle and a political weapon. A weapon is useful because it can be aimed at the other side. A principle is supposed to constrain us even when doing so is inconvenient.

And that brings the argument back to the line we have been tracing. The problem is not that Americans disagree. The problem is what happens when disagreement becomes a justification for denying the other side the ordinary protections of political life. When that happens, the question is no longer simply whether we can win the argument. It becomes whether we are still willing to share the same political system with the people we are trying to defeat.

Where the Line Becomes Visible

The line we have been tracing through this article is beginning to come into focus. Disagreement is normal. Polarization is dangerous but manageable. Delegitimization threatens the democratic process. Dehumanization makes political violence easier to justify. Violence attacks the possibility of peaceful disagreement itself. These stages are related, but they are not interchangeable, and none of them automatically produces the next. A society can become deeply polarized without becoming violent, and political opponents can use extraordinarily harsh language without abandoning the political system entirely.

That distinction matters because democracy is not designed to eliminate conflict. It is designed to contain it. Americans can disagree intensely, recognize one another as citizens, and still return to the negotiating table. Institutions can absorb extraordinary political conflict. Elections can change governments without destroying the political system. Courts can resolve disputes that citizens cannot resolve among themselves. Legislatures can negotiate compromises that leave both sides dissatisfied. Protest can produce reform without producing violence. Even political pressure, including boycotts and organized opposition, can remain within the boundaries of a functioning democratic society.

That capacity is one of the great achievements of democratic government, and it is easy to overlook precisely because successful political containment is rarely dramatic. We notice the election that produces a constitutional crisis, but not the thousands of elections in which one side loses and prepares to compete again. We remember the protest that becomes violent, but not the countless protests that

remain peaceful. We remember the political conflicts that break institutions, while ordinary political disagreements disappear into history because the institutions successfully absorbed them. A functioning democracy does not require Americans to stop fighting over what they believe. It requires them to continue fighting through political means rather than treating every disagreement as a reason to abandon the system itself.

People can also move backward as well as forward along the progression we have been examining. A period of intense polarization can give way to compromise. A political opponent who has been described in extreme terms can once again be treated as a legitimate participant in political life. Citizens can become exhausted by conflict and decide that preserving the ability to live together matters more than winning every argument. Political systems have mechanisms for doing exactly this: elections, courts, legislatures, public debate, negotiation, protest, organizing, and the simple passage of time can all create opportunities for conflict to be contained rather than escalated.

The question, then, is not whether Americans are divided. We have always been divided. The more difficult question is whether there comes a point at which ordinary political disagreement can no longer be contained by the institutions and habits that make peaceful disagreement possible. There is an important difference between arguing over what government should do and arguing over whether the people on the other side have a legitimate place in the political community at all. There is another difference between believing that an opponent should lose an election and believing that the opponent should never be allowed to exercise political power. Those distinctions are where the line begins to become visible.

This is also why the historical comparison that follows has to be handled carefully. The existence of political conflict today does not mean that America is repeating the circumstances of any previous crisis. The United States of the present is not the United States of 1860, and history does not provide a script that the country is required to follow. The value of looking backward is not to declare that the same outcome is inevitable. It is to examine what happened when Americans reached a point at which the ordinary mechanisms of political disagreement were no longer sufficient to contain the conflict.

There is one historical example where Americans ultimately reached that point. It was not simply a disagreement over policy, nor merely a period of extraordinary anger between political factions. It involved fundamental questions about rights, political power, the institution of slavery, and the future of the Union itself. Americans had spent years attempting to resolve those conflicts through elections, legislation, compromise, political organizing, public argument, and the other mechanisms of democratic government. Eventually, those mechanisms could no longer contain the conflict.

That example is not a metaphor, and it should not be used casually.

It was the Civil War.

The United States has survived political crises before. It has survived bitter elections, riots, assassinations, economic depressions, wars, ideological movements, racial conflict, constitutional crises, and enormous cultural transformations. It has endured periods when Americans were convinced that the country was moving in the wrong direction, that the opposing political faction was threatening everything they believed in, or that the political system itself was failing. Some of those conflicts

produced lasting political changes. Others produced violence, repression, or institutional damage. Yet the country continued.

The Civil War forces us to confront the most uncomfortable version of the question we have been asking throughout this article: When does a disagreement become too fundamental for a country to remain together?

That question requires us to be careful about what we mean by “too fundamental.” A country does not become incapable of surviving simply because its citizens are angry with one another. Anger is common in politics. Neither does a country necessarily become unstable because people protest, boycott, organize against one another, or use harsh political language. Those activities can be disruptive, uncomfortable, and deeply consequential, but they remain part of political life when people continue to recognize one another as participants in the same political community.

The harder question comes when the disagreement moves beyond what government should do and toward questions about who is entitled to participate in the political system at all. What happens when Americans fundamentally disagree about who possesses rights, who belongs in the political community, and whether the other side is entitled to exercise political power? What happens when losing an election is no longer understood as a temporary political defeat, but as something that cannot be accepted because the people who won are considered fundamentally illegitimate?

That is a different kind of conflict.

The distinction is important because democratic government depends on a particular kind of uncertainty. No political faction is supposed to possess permanent ownership of the country. Elections determine who exercises political authority for a period of time, but they do not determine who is entitled to remain a citizen. A political party can lose power without disappearing. A movement can suffer a political defeat and continue organizing. Citizens can believe that the government is profoundly wrong and still use the institutions of that government to argue, protest, vote, litigate, organize, and attempt to change it.

The system becomes much more difficult to sustain when the disagreement is no longer about who should govern, but about whether the other side has any legitimate claim to govern at all.

That is the point at which the historical example of the Civil War becomes especially important. It does not provide a prediction about modern America, and it should not be used as a convenient comparison every time political rhetoric becomes heated. The circumstances were different, the central conflict was different, and the consequences of the Civil War were extraordinarily specific to the nineteenth-century United States. But the historical episode does force us to examine what happens when a political disagreement becomes so deeply connected to questions of rights, political power, and the future of the country that the ordinary mechanisms for resolving disagreement begin to fail.

That is the question we cannot avoid.

And that is where the Civil War becomes more than a historical event. It becomes a case study in what happens when political containment finally breaks down.

The Civil War Question

If we are going to ask whether disagreement can become so fundamental that a country can no longer remain together, eventually we have to confront the most obvious example in American history. The Civil War was not simply a particularly angry political argument, and it was not the result of Americans suddenly discovering that they disliked one another. The conflict had been developing for decades through elections, congressional battles, newspapers, protests, political movements, court decisions, compromises, and increasingly bitter arguments over the future of the country. Americans repeatedly attempted to manage those disagreements through the political system. Eventually, however, the political system could no longer contain them.

That distinction is important because the Civil War was not simply a conflict between two groups of Americans who had different opinions. The disagreement had become connected to fundamental questions about the structure of American society and the political power of slavery. The issue was not merely whether one political party should control the government or whether one region should have greater influence than another. It involved the future expansion of slavery, the rights and status of millions of enslaved people, the balance of political power between free and slave states, and ultimately the question of whether the existing Union could continue under those conditions.

The political system spent years attempting to find ways to postpone or manage those questions. Compromise was repeatedly attempted. Political coalitions changed. Parties fractured and reorganized. Congressional battles became increasingly intense. The territories became central to the dispute because every new territory raised the question of whether slavery would be permitted to expand. The country continued to hold elections and pass laws, but each political solution seemed to create another conflict that had not actually been resolved.

The election of Abraham Lincoln in 1860 brought the crisis to a decisive point, but the election itself did not create the underlying conflict. Lincoln's victory demonstrated that political power could change through the electoral system, while Southern secession demonstrated that some political leaders were no longer willing to accept the consequences of that system. South Carolina seceded in December 1860, followed by Mississippi, Florida, Alabama, Georgia, Louisiana, and Texas, with additional states joining the Confederacy after the conflict began. The United States then entered a war over whether the Union itself would survive.

This is where the progression we have been examining becomes historically significant. A political system can tolerate an enormous amount of disagreement when the people involved still believe that the system provides a legitimate way to resolve their disagreements. Elections matter because the losing side can organize for the next election. Legislatures matter because political opponents can negotiate. Courts matter because disputes can be submitted to legal judgment. Protest matters because citizens can demand change without physically overthrowing the government. But all of those mechanisms depend upon a basic assumption: that the people participating in the conflict still recognize the political system, and one another, as legitimate participants in a shared country.

The Civil War represented the collapse of that assumption in the most consequential way possible. Secession was not simply another form of political protest. It was a rejection of the existing Union by states that concluded they could no longer remain within it under the political circumstances that had

developed. The federal government, in turn, rejected the idea that individual states could simply leave the Union. At that point, the disagreement was no longer confined to competing arguments about what government policy should be. The disagreement had become a conflict over the existence and authority of the political community itself.

That is why the Civil War is such an important case study for the argument of this article. It shows us that there is a difference between a country being deeply divided and a country reaching the point where its divisions can no longer be contained through ordinary political mechanisms. Americans had been divided before 1860, and they remained divided afterward. Division itself was not the unique feature. The extraordinary feature was that the disagreement had become so fundamental that the political system could no longer provide an acceptable method for resolving it peacefully.

There is another reason we need to be careful with this comparison. It is tempting, especially in an age of intense political rhetoric, to look at any period of polarization and immediately reach for the Civil War as the ultimate warning. But historical analogy is useful only when we understand both the similarities and the differences. The United States of 2026 is not the United States of 1860. The political institutions, social conditions, constitutional circumstances, economy, communications environment, and central political conflicts are different. The existence of serious polarization today does not establish that the country is following the same path.

The useful lesson is therefore not that modern America is approaching another Civil War. It is that the Civil War gives us a historical example of what happens when political disagreement moves beyond ordinary disputes and becomes connected to fundamental questions about rights, political authority, and the future of the political community itself. It allows us to ask a more precise question than “How divided are we?” We can instead ask: What happens when the people on opposite sides of a political conflict no longer believe that the same political system can produce an acceptable answer?

That is the Civil War question.

And answering it requires us to look more closely at what Americans were actually fighting about.

Secession Was the Breaking Point

After Lincoln won the 1860 presidential election, South Carolina seceded in December of that year. Mississippi, Florida, Alabama, Georgia, Louisiana, and Texas followed, and additional states seceded after the outbreak of war. The seceding states created the Confederate States of America, claiming that the Union was a compact from which states could withdraw. Lincoln and the federal government rejected that interpretation and maintained that secession was legally invalid.

The disagreement had therefore reached another level.

The question was no longer simply, “What should the government do?” It had become, “Who is the government?” That is a profoundly different question because the answer determines who has the authority to make decisions in the first place. As long as political opponents accept that they are participating in the same political system, they can fight over elections, legislation, courts, and policy.

Once one side concludes that the political system itself is no longer binding upon them, the mechanisms for resolving disagreement begin to disappear.

Secession was therefore more than an expression of political dissatisfaction. It was an assertion that the existing political relationship between the states and the federal government could no longer continue. The seceding states were not simply demanding that Washington change a policy or elect a different president. They were attempting to withdraw from the Union altogether and establish a separate political government. The federal government, meanwhile, rejected the premise that a state could unilaterally leave the Union.

That created a problem for which ordinary political compromise offered very little room. A compromise over legislation could produce a different law. A compromise over an election could produce another election. A compromise over the administration of government could divide responsibilities or change procedures. But there is much less room for compromise when the underlying disagreement is whether two sides are even members of the same political community.

Lincoln's First Inaugural Address attempted to answer that question by arguing that the Union was older than the Constitution itself and that secession could not legally dissolve it. At the same time, Lincoln sought to reassure the South that his administration did not intend to abolish slavery where it already existed. His position was that the Union had to survive even though the country remained deeply divided over slavery. Those assurances did not prevent secession or avert war. Source: Lincoln, First Inaugural Address (1861) [Read Lincoln’s First Inaugural Address]

That distinction is important. The federal government's immediate position on secession and the larger moral conflict over slavery were related, but they were not identical questions. The country was confronting both a dispute over the institution of slavery and a constitutional dispute over whether individual states possessed the authority to leave the Union. One conflict concerned the rights and status of millions of enslaved people; the other concerned the continued existence and authority of the United States as a single political community.

The two questions nevertheless collided because the political crisis surrounding slavery had helped produce the secession crisis. What had previously been fought through elections, congressional battles, compromises, territorial disputes, political movements, and public argument had now reached the point where one side was attempting to leave the political system rather than continue fighting within it.

The attempt to preserve the Union through ordinary political means failed.

And that is the point at which disagreement became something fundamentally different. The issue was no longer simply whether Americans could find a policy on which they could agree. It was whether they could continue to recognize one another as participants in the same political system at all.

The next step was war.

When the Political System Breaks

The firing on Fort Sumter in April 1861 transformed the constitutional and political crisis into open war. The conflict that followed would last four years and cost hundreds of thousands of lives. The

National Archives describes the war as the greatest test of the American experiment, with the survival of the United States as a single nation at stake. The political mechanisms that had previously been used to manage the conflict had reached their limit. Elections had occurred, compromises had been attempted, arguments had been made, and competing interpretations of constitutional authority had been presented. Now the disagreement was being settled through military force.

That is the point at which the political system had truly broken down. A democratic system does not require Americans to agree with one another. It does not even require them to like one another. It requires some accepted mechanism through which disagreements can be fought over without destroying the political community itself. When that mechanism fails, the consequences are fundamentally different from an ordinary political defeat. The losing side is no longer simply preparing for the next election or the next legislative battle; the conflict has moved outside the system that was supposed to contain it.

But even then, the meaning of the conflict continued to change.

At the beginning of the war, preserving the Union was the central objective of the Lincoln administration. The Emancipation Proclamation of 1863 fundamentally changed the character of the conflict by declaring enslaved people in areas still in rebellion to be free and authorizing the enlistment of Black men in the Union armed forces. By the end of the war, nearly 200,000 Black soldiers and sailors had served the Union. The war that began as a struggle to preserve the Union became inseparable from the destruction of slavery.[National Archives: Emancipation Proclamation] Source: National Park Service: African Americans in the Civil War

That transformation matters because it complicates the way we often tell historical stories after the outcome is already known. Looking backward, it can be tempting to describe the Civil War as though everyone involved understood from the beginning exactly what the conflict would become and exactly how it would end. They did not. The people living through the crisis were making decisions under circumstances that were changing around them. Their objectives, arguments, and understanding of the conflict could change as events unfolded.

That is important to our larger question because political crises are not static. A disagreement can begin as one thing and become something else. A dispute over policy can become a dispute over political authority. A dispute over political authority can become a dispute over whether the political community itself should continue to exist. And once a conflict reaches that point, the actions taken by government and citizens can create new consequences that further change the nature of the conflict.

The Civil War demonstrates that progression particularly clearly. The original constitutional crisis surrounding secession did not simply disappear when fighting began. Questions about the Union remained central, but the war also created circumstances in which slavery, emancipation, military service, citizenship, and the future structure of American society became increasingly inseparable from the conflict. The country entered the war with one set of immediate political questions and emerged from it facing a profoundly different set of constitutional and social questions.

That does not mean that the later development of the war makes the original political disagreement unimportant. It means that once political systems break down, events can begin to move beyond the

intentions of the people who started the conflict. Governments make decisions in response to circumstances. Opponents respond to those decisions. New groups become involved. New grievances emerge. Policies that were unimaginable before the crisis can become possible during it.

History rarely gives us clean categories.

Political conflicts evolve. Governments respond to circumstances. Movements change their goals. People who enter a conflict for one reason can discover another reason along the way. The meaning of a national crisis can change while the crisis is still happening.

The People Who Did Not Want the War

Another lesson is often lost when we tell the story too simply: not every American wanted the conflict to continue. Once we know how the Civil War ended, it is easy to look backward and imagine the country as though it had divided neatly into two camps, with the North standing for the Union and the South standing for secession, and with everyone on each side sharing essentially the same objectives. The reality was considerably more complicated. Americans disagreed not only about whether the war should be fought, but about why it was being fought, what the government's powers should be, what should happen to slavery, and what the country should look like when the conflict was over.

There were peace movements in both the North and South. There were Americans who opposed the war, Americans who opposed emancipation, Americans who opposed secession, Americans who supported the Union but criticized Lincoln's policies, and Americans who believed the war was necessary but disagreed about how it should be conducted. These positions did not necessarily fit neatly together. Someone could oppose secession while also opposing emancipation. Someone could support the Union while believing Lincoln had exceeded his constitutional authority. Someone could believe slavery was wrong while still opposing the war as the means of ending it. Someone could support the war while objecting to particular military decisions or restrictions on civil liberties.

That complexity matters because it demonstrates that political disagreement does not disappear simply because a country enters a crisis. In fact, crisis can make disagreement more consequential because the government's decisions become more immediate and the costs of those decisions become more severe. During ordinary political conflict, an argument over a policy can remain largely theoretical. During a war, the same argument can involve someone's liberty, property, family, livelihood, or life. The pressure to conform therefore becomes much greater precisely when the consequences of political decisions become greater.

The Union itself contained deep disagreement about the war. Opposition politicians, newspapers, activists, and ordinary citizens continued to challenge the administration. Some were accused of disloyalty; some were arrested; some faced suppression. The existence of these disagreements does not mean that every criticism of the government was reasonable or that every person who opposed Lincoln's policies was acting in good faith. It does, however, demonstrate that the boundaries between legitimate dissent, political opposition, and disloyalty were themselves contested.

That is an important distinction.

A government fighting for its survival has a legitimate interest in preventing actions that directly assist an enemy. But that is not the same thing as saying that every person who criticizes the government is

assisting the enemy. Political opposition can exist during a war because citizenship does not disappear when the country enters an emergency. The difficult question is where legitimate government authority ends and the suppression of political disagreement begins.

The Civil War therefore provides an important example of something we have already encountered throughout this article: even during an existential national crisis, the government still has to confront the problem of political dissent. The existence of a war does not magically turn every critic into an enemy. Nor does opposing a government's policy automatically make someone a traitor. Those distinctions become extraordinarily difficult during emergencies, which is precisely why they matter.

There is another reason this matters to the larger argument of this article. Earlier, we examined how political conflict can move from disagreement to polarization, from polarization to delegitimization, and from delegitimization toward dehumanization and violence. The Civil War demonstrates what happens when that progression reaches its most destructive point, but it also reminds us that even at the height of conflict, Americans did not suddenly become identical members of opposing political armies. There remained disagreement within the Union, disagreement within the Confederacy, disagreement about the purposes of the war, disagreement about its conduct, and disagreement about what the country should become afterward.

That makes the historical lesson more complicated—and more useful.

If we reduce the Civil War to a story about two sides that hated each other so much that they eventually fought, we miss the political process that produced the crisis. We also miss the people who continued trying to influence that process through elections, newspapers, speeches, political organizations, religious movements, peace efforts, and public criticism. The failure of political containment did not mean that politics itself ceased to exist. It meant that political disagreement had reached a point where ordinary political mechanisms were no longer sufficient to contain the conflict.

That distinction brings us back to the central problem of cancel culture.

A society does not become dangerous merely because its citizens disagree intensely. Nor does it become dangerous merely because people attempt to persuade, criticize, boycott, protest, or organize against one another. Those are ordinary features of political life. The danger begins when disagreement itself becomes evidence of disloyalty, when criticism is treated as proof of hostility, and when the existence of an opposing political position becomes sufficient reason to remove the opponent from the legitimate political community.

The Civil War shows the ultimate consequences of a political system that failed to contain a fundamental conflict. But it also shows why preserving space for dissent matters before a conflict reaches that point.

The existence of a war does not eliminate the need for political freedom.

It makes the need to defend the distinction between dissent and disloyalty even more important.

The Dangerous Logic of “For the Good of the Country”

Every political age has people who believe the stakes are so high that ordinary rules should be suspended. Sometimes they are correct that the stakes are unusually high. Governments really do face circumstances in which decisions must be made quickly, threats must be addressed, and actions that would be unacceptable under ordinary conditions may become necessary. The existence of an emergency, however, does not answer the more difficult question of how much power should be exercised in response to it.

That distinction matters because the phrase “for the good of the country” can justify almost anything if we stop asking what limits still apply. A person who believes the country is facing an existential threat can begin to see ordinary political opposition not as part of the democratic process, but as an obstacle to survival. Once that happens, censorship can be described as protecting the public, surveillance as preventing sabotage, suppression as maintaining order, punishment as accountability, and even violence as self-defense. The language changes, but the underlying logic is remarkably consistent: the danger is so great that the normal rules cannot be allowed to interfere with defeating it.

The danger lies in allowing the seriousness of a political disagreement to become the justification for eliminating the political disagreement itself.

This is where the earlier stages of our progression become important. If political opponents are merely people with whom we disagree, their arguments can be answered. If they become enemies, however, their political activity can begin to look like a threat. If they are then portrayed as a threat to the survival of the country itself, actions that would ordinarily be considered unacceptable can begin to appear necessary. The argument no longer becomes “I disagree with you.” It becomes “I cannot allow you to continue doing this because what you are doing is dangerous.”

That is a much more powerful justification.

And it is precisely why it deserves scrutiny.

The Civil War provides an especially serious example because the federal government really was facing an extraordinary crisis. The Union had been attacked. States had attempted to leave the United States. A large-scale armed conflict was underway, and the survival of the national government was genuinely at stake. It would therefore be misleading to pretend that the government could simply behave as though nothing unusual were happening. War creates legitimate responsibilities that do not exist during ordinary political disagreement.

But acknowledging that fact does not eliminate the problem of limits.

Extraordinary circumstances can require extraordinary government action. They do not automatically make every extraordinary action legitimate. The existence of a real emergency does not mean that every person who invokes the emergency is correct about what must be done, nor does it mean that every restriction imposed in its name will remain necessary once circumstances change. The harder the circumstances become, the more important it becomes to distinguish between powers that are genuinely necessary to address the emergency and powers that are justified by the emergency but extend beyond it.[Constitution Annotated: Government coercion and First Amendment]

This is one of the recurring problems of political power. A government may acquire a power because circumstances genuinely require it, but the existence of that power can create pressure to use it more broadly. A measure introduced as temporary can become normalized. A restriction aimed at a specific threat can expand to encompass political opponents. A definition of “dangerous” can become broader as the political conflict intensifies. And once the government has demonstrated that extraordinary measures are possible, future leaders may inherit those same powers without facing the same circumstances that originally produced them.

The principle therefore has to be larger than the particular political moment.

If we believe constitutional limits matter when our opponents are in power, they must also matter when our own side is in power. If freedom of speech matters when our political allies are being criticized, it must also matter when our political opponents are being criticized. If due process matters when someone we support is accused, it must also matter when someone we strongly oppose is accused. If the government should not be permitted to suppress dissent merely because dissent is inconvenient, that principle cannot depend upon whether we agree with the dissent.

That is the Consistency Test again. And the test becomes particularly difficult when we are convinced that the stakes are enormous.

Imagine that you believe the country is facing an existential threat. Your political opponents believe the same thing. You believe they are the threat. They believe you are the threat. Each side can therefore convince itself that extraordinary action is defensive rather than aggressive.

That is one of the most dangerous dynamics in political conflict because both sides can sincerely believe they are acting to preserve the country. Once that happens, the question “Who started it?” becomes less useful than the question “What principles are we willing to abandon in order to defeat the other side?” The answer matters because political power changes hands.

The emergency measure you support today may become the weapon your political opponents control tomorrow. The precedent you establish against people you believe deserve it does not come with a guarantee that it will only ever be used against people you believe deserve it. Government power is rarely permanently owned by the people who create it.

This does not mean that every emergency action is equivalent to authoritarianism, or that constitutional government requires leaders to remain passive when the country faces a genuine threat. That would be another kind of historical simplification. The real question is more difficult: how does a free society respond to a genuine threat without allowing the existence of that threat to become a permanent justification for eliminating the freedoms that make the society free?

The Civil War does not provide a simple answer to that question. What it does provide is a warning about the pressure that crisis places on political institutions and political judgment. When people believe the survival of the country is at stake, the temptation to treat disagreement as dangerous becomes much stronger. And once political disagreement itself is treated as dangerous, the distance between defending the political system and suppressing the people who challenge it can become dangerously small.

That is why “for the good of the country” should never be the end of the argument.

It should be the beginning of a harder one: What power is actually necessary? What limits still apply? Who decides? And would we accept the same rule if our political opponents were the ones using it?

The Consistency Test Gets Harder

Imagine that you believe the country is facing an existential threat. Your political opponents believe the same thing. You believe they are the threat. They believe you are the threat.

Each side can therefore convince itself that extraordinary action is defensive rather than aggressive. The same action can look completely different depending upon which side is taking it. When our opponents use government power against people we agree with, we may call it repression. When people we agree with use similar power against our opponents, we may call it necessary, responsible, or protective. The principle has not actually changed. Only the identity of the people exercising the power has changed.

This is one of the most dangerous dynamics in political conflict because both sides can sincerely believe they are acting to preserve the country. Neither side necessarily has to believe that it is doing something wrong. In fact, some of the most consequential abuses of political power can begin with people who are convinced that they are preventing something worse. Once the other side has been defined as an existential threat, almost any action can be presented as defensive because the alternative is portrayed as catastrophe.

That is where the Consistency Test becomes harder.

It is relatively easy to defend a principle when doing so costs us nothing. It is harder when the principle protects people we believe are wrong. It is harder still when we believe those people are dangerous. And it becomes harder again when we are told that allowing those people to continue exercising political influence could put the entire country at risk.

That is the moment when principles are actually tested.

If we believe that political opponents have a right to speak, does that right continue when we believe their speech is dangerous? If we believe people have a right to organize politically, does that right continue when we believe their organization threatens the country? If we believe government should not punish people merely for holding unpopular political opinions, does that principle still apply when the opinions are ones we consider profoundly harmful?

These questions do not have to be answered identically in every circumstance. There can be genuine distinctions between protected political disagreement and conduct that directly violates the rights of others. There can be circumstances in which government has legitimate authority to intervene. But that is precisely why the distinction matters. If everything we dislike can be reclassified as a threat, then the principle protecting political disagreement has effectively disappeared.

Once that happens, each side has an incentive to describe the other as dangerous. And that creates a feedback loop.

One side takes extraordinary action because it believes the other side is dangerous. The other side experiences that action as proof that the first side is dangerous. It responds in kind. The first side then points to the response as additional evidence that its original fears were justified.

Each side can now point to the other and say, “See? We were right about them.” The cycle becomes self-reinforcing.

This is why the question “Who started it?” becomes less useful than the question “What principles are we willing to abandon in order to defeat the other side?” There may be historical value in determining who acted first, and accountability still matters. But identifying the first offense does not tell us whether the response is justified. If every escalation becomes proof that the next escalation is necessary, eventually the political system can become trapped in a cycle in which each side believes it is merely responding to the other.

That is how political conflict can become detached from the principles that were supposedly being defended.

The answer matters because political power changes hands.

The emergency measure you support today may become the weapon your political opponents control tomorrow. The precedent you establish against one group does not remain permanently attached to that group. Once a government has exercised a power, future governments inherit the possibility of exercising it. Once a political culture accepts a particular justification for suppressing dissent, that justification can be adopted by people whose politics are completely different from the people who originally established it.

This is why consistency cannot be measured only by asking whether we approve of the immediate result.

We also have to ask whether we approve of the principle.

Would we accept the same government power if the president belonged to the other party? Would we accept the same restriction if the people being restricted were our political allies? Would we still defend the same rule if the newspaper being silenced were publishing arguments we agreed with? Would we still believe extraordinary action was justified if the political circumstances were reversed?

Those questions are uncomfortable because they remove the protection of political identity. They force us to consider whether we actually believe in a principle or whether we simply believe in the use of that principle when it benefits our side.

That distinction is central to everything we have examined so far.

Cancel culture is often defended by appealing to accountability, consequences, public pressure, or the right of people and institutions to decide whom they will support. Those concepts can be legitimate. But the same mechanisms can also become tools for political exclusion when the objective shifts from responding to specific conduct toward making certain people illegitimate participants in public life.

The historical lesson is not that every act of political pressure leads to catastrophe. It does not. The lesson is that the justification for extraordinary political action deserves the same scrutiny regardless of who is making it.

The Consistency Test asks us to imagine the power in different hands.

If we would condemn an action when our opponents use it but defend it when our allies use it, we should at least recognize that we are no longer applying a consistent principle.

And once a political system reaches the point where each side believes its own extraordinary actions are necessary but the other side's extraordinary actions are inherently illegitimate, the possibility of peaceful political disagreement becomes much harder to preserve.

That is the deeper danger.

The question is no longer simply whether we can defeat our political opponents.

It is whether we can defeat them without destroying the principles that allow us to remain political opponents rather than becoming enemies.

The Civil War Was a Failure of Political Containment

This is ultimately what makes the Civil War relevant to the argument of this article. The United States did not fall into war because Americans discovered disagreement for the first time. Americans had been arguing about slavery, federal power, states' rights, territorial expansion, economic interests, political parties, and the meaning of the Constitution for decades. They had elections, political parties, newspapers, congressional debates, court decisions, compromises, protests, and political movements through which those disagreements could be fought.

The problem was that those mechanisms increasingly stopped being capable of containing the disagreement.

That distinction matters. A democracy is not designed to eliminate conflict. It is designed to give conflict somewhere to go. Elections give citizens a way to change political leadership. Legislatures give competing interests a place to negotiate. Courts provide a mechanism for resolving certain disputes under established law. Political parties organize competing visions of government and allow those visions to compete for power. Protest allows citizens to challenge decisions without necessarily rejecting the political system itself.

None of those mechanisms guarantees agreement. They are not supposed to.

Their purpose is to make disagreement survivable.

The Civil War represents the catastrophic failure of that process. The disagreements did not simply become more intense; they became increasingly difficult to resolve within the same political framework. The conflict became tied to slavery, territorial expansion, constitutional authority, state sovereignty, political power, and competing understandings of freedom and citizenship. By 1861, the

dispute had moved beyond the question of how Americans should govern themselves and reached the question of whether they would continue governing themselves as one nation.

That is a much higher threshold than simply being politically angry.

It is also important to recognize that the failure did not happen overnight. The Civil War followed decades in which Americans repeatedly attempted to manage the underlying conflict through political means. Compromise could postpone a crisis, but postponement was not the same thing as resolution. Political victories could settle one election or one congressional battle, but they did not necessarily settle the larger question underneath it. Each successive confrontation placed greater pressure on institutions that were being asked to contain a disagreement that was becoming increasingly fundamental.

Eventually, the argument was no longer simply about which policy the federal government should adopt. It became an argument over the structure of the political community itself.

That is where political containment becomes especially important to our discussion. A political system can survive enormous disagreement when the people participating in that system still accept certain basic premises: that their opponents are legitimate participants, that political defeat is temporary rather than permanent, that institutions retain legitimacy even when they produce an outcome they dislike, and that political power can change hands without requiring the destruction of the other side.

When those assumptions begin to disappear, disagreement becomes much harder to contain.

This is also why the Civil War should not be casually invoked every time Americans have a bitter election or an ugly political argument. Doing so can actually obscure the historical lesson. The Civil War was extraordinarily destructive precisely because the underlying disagreement was extraordinarily fundamental. It involved questions of human bondage, political sovereignty, constitutional authority, and the future structure of the nation itself.

The question for us is not whether modern America is “just like 1860.”

It isn't.

Nor is the useful lesson that every period of intense polarization eventually ends in civil war. History does not support such a simple formula. Americans can become deeply divided and still maintain a functioning political system. They can protest, boycott, organize, campaign against one another, criticize government, lose elections, win elections, and fight bitterly over public policy without concluding that the political system itself has become unacceptable.

The more useful question is whether we can recognize the earlier warning signs that matter in any democracy: when opponents cease to be legitimate participants, when political defeat becomes unacceptable, when institutions themselves are treated as illegitimate whenever they produce an unwanted result, and when people begin to believe that the other side must be eliminated rather than defeated through ordinary political means.

Those warning signs do not automatically lead to violence. But they weaken the mechanisms that allow disagreement to remain political rather than becoming something more dangerous.

And that brings us to the other half of the Civil War story.

There is another part of the Civil War story that matters just as much. The United States survived.

The Union was not permanently dissolved. Slavery was abolished through the Thirteenth Amendment. The constitutional order was altered by the Fourteenth and Fifteenth Amendments, and the meaning of American citizenship and rights changed profoundly. The country that emerged from the war was not the same country that had entered it. Primary documents: 13th Amendment | 14th Amendment | 15th Amendment

That fact matters because it prevents this section from becoming a simple story of inevitable collapse. The failure of political containment did not mean the American political experiment ended permanently. The country eventually found a way through the conflict, although the way through came at an extraordinary human cost.

That does not make the war a success story.

Nearly four years of war, enormous death and destruction, the destruction of communities, the emancipation of millions of enslaved people through a process born from war, and the generations of political and racial conflict that followed are not evidence that political disagreement can simply be solved through force. Even when a war produces a profound constitutional transformation, the human cost cannot be separated from the result.

The lesson is almost the opposite.

A democratic system should work extraordinarily hard to prevent disagreements from reaching the point where war becomes the mechanism for deciding them. The purpose of political institutions is not to make every side happy. It is to provide a means by which people who profoundly disagree can continue living under the same political system while fighting for their competing visions of what that system should become.

That may be one of the most important distinctions in the entire argument of this article. Political containment does not mean agreement. It means keeping disagreement within a system where disagreement can still be expressed, challenged, defeated, reconsidered, and eventually returned to the political process.

The Civil War demonstrates what happens when that containment fails.

And it also demonstrates something else: even after a political system breaks under the weight of disagreement, rebuilding it does not erase the damage that occurred while it was broken.

Because once political disagreement becomes war, everybody loses something—even when one side ultimately wins.

The Question for Us

So, when does a country become too divided to remain together?

The Civil War does not give us a simple number, percentage, or polling threshold. It gives us a historical example in which political disagreement became inseparable from fundamental questions of human freedom, political sovereignty, constitutional authority, and the future of the nation. It shows us that division becomes particularly dangerous when the disagreement is no longer simply about what government should do, but about what government is, who has the authority to govern, who belongs within the political community, and whether the people on the other side are still entitled to participate in determining the country's future.

That does not mean every serious political disagreement is a threat to the survival of the country. Democracies are supposed to contain serious disagreements. In fact, the existence of profound disagreement can be evidence that people are still exercising political freedom. The problem begins when disagreement itself becomes unacceptable—when losing an election is treated as illegitimate, when political opponents are regarded as enemies rather than fellow citizens, when institutions are considered legitimate only when they produce the desired result, or when compromise becomes indistinguishable from surrender.

That is why our present disagreements deserve neither panic nor complacency.

Panic assumes that division itself is proof of impending collapse. It is not. Americans have been divided before, sometimes extraordinarily so, and the political system has survived. But complacency can be just as dangerous because democratic institutions are not self-sustaining machines that continue functioning regardless of what citizens believe about one another. They depend upon people who are willing to accept political defeat, recognize the legitimacy of their opponents, and continue participating in a common system even when they believe the stakes are enormous.

We should not pretend that every modern political conflict is equivalent to the sectional crisis of the 1850s. The historical differences are enormous, and treating every period of political turmoil as a potential repetition of the Civil War would flatten history rather than teach us anything useful from it. But neither should we assume that democratic institutions are indestructible simply because they have survived previous conflicts. The fact that a system has survived a crisis tells us that survival is possible; it does not mean that survival happens automatically.

The survival of a democracy depends partly on whether citizens continue to recognize one another as participants in the same political system even when they profoundly disagree about what that system should do.

That may be the more difficult question beneath everything we have examined so far.

Can we disagree about the direction of the country without disagreeing about whether we still belong to the same country?

Can we believe that our opponents are profoundly wrong without believing that their participation in political life is itself illegitimate?

Can we lose an election without believing that the government has somehow ceased to be ours?

Can we fight for fundamental changes in American society while still accepting that the people who oppose those changes have the same right to argue, organize, vote, protest, and attempt to persuade their fellow citizens?

Those questions bring us back to something much more basic than polarization. They bring us back to the word Americans have placed in the name of the country itself. And that brings us back to a phrase Americans have been repeating since the founding:

The United States.

We call ourselves United States. But what exactly does united mean? Does it mean that we agree? Does it mean that we share the same values?

Does it mean that we believe the same things about freedom, government, religion, rights, morality, or America itself? Or could it mean something much harder—and much more important?

Could it mean that we have agreed to remain one country despite the fact that we do not agree with one another?

We Call Ourselves the United States

There is something almost strange about the name we gave this country.

The United States of America.

We use the word “United” so casually that it can disappear into the background. It is printed on our money, spoken in official ceremonies, written into government documents, and repeated so often that we rarely stop to ask what it actually means. Yet after everything we have just examined—Revolution, abolition, Civil War, Reconstruction, suffrage, Civil Rights, Vietnam, political protest, boycotts, polarization, and the modern struggle over who gets to speak and who gets to participate—the word deserves another look. [National Archives: 19th Amendment and suffrage movement]

What does it mean to be united?

If unity means agreement, then the United States has almost never been united. Americans disagreed before the Constitution was written. They disagreed about the Constitution itself. Federalists and Anti-Federalists argued over the proper structure of government. Americans fought over slavery, tariffs, banks, immigration, labor, religion, women's suffrage, civil rights, war, taxation, regulation, and the role of government in private life. They have disagreed about what freedom means, what equality requires, how much power government should possess, and whose freedom deserves protection.

Some of those disagreements were minor. Others were not. Some could be resolved through ordinary political bargaining; others took generations, constitutional amendments, social movements, war, or profound changes in American law and culture. The country has repeatedly been forced to confront the fact that being part of the same political community does not mean having the same beliefs about what that community should be.

And yet the country continued to call itself the United States.

That is worth taking seriously.

We often talk about unity as though it means bringing people to the same conclusion. A united country, in that understanding, is one in which citizens share the same values, support the same institutions, agree on the same basic questions, and perhaps even want the same kind of country. Under that definition, disagreement is evidence of division, and division is evidence that unity has failed.

But there is another possibility.

Perhaps being united does not require us to agree.

Perhaps it requires us to remain part of the same political community while we disagree.

That is a much more demanding idea of unity than simple agreement. It means accepting that the person on the other side of a political argument is still a citizen. It means accepting that political defeat does not erase political rights. It means recognizing that someone can hold beliefs we consider profoundly wrong without automatically becoming someone who must be removed from public life.

And if that is what unity means, then disagreement is not necessarily the opposite of unity.

It may be one of the conditions under which unity is tested.

The question, then, is not whether Americans can eliminate their differences. History has already answered that question: we cannot. The more important question is whether Americans can remain one political community without requiring one another to become the same.

Out of Many

The founding generation gave us another phrase that may provide a better clue. **E Pluribus Unum.** Out of many, one.

The phrase appeared on the Great Seal and became an important expression of the new republic's attempt to transform thirteen separate colonies into a single nation. The Smithsonian notes that *E Pluribus Unum*—"Out of many, one"—became associated with the creation of the United States from the many states and peoples that constituted the new nation.[National Archives: Great Seal]

Notice what the phrase does not say. It does not say, "Out of agreement, one." It does not say, "Out of uniformity, one." It does not say, "Out of people who believe the same things, one." It starts with many.

That may be the more important part.

We sometimes read "out of many, one" as though the many were merely a problem that had to be overcome in order to reach the one. But the phrase can be understood another way. The many are not an error in the equation. They are the starting point. The achievement is not that the many disappeared; it is that the many became capable of existing within a common political structure.

That distinction matters enormously when we talk about political disagreement.

The American experiment did not begin with a population that had already reached consensus. It began with different colonies, different economies, different religious traditions, different political interests,

and different ideas about government. Those differences did not suddenly disappear when the colonies became states or when the states became part of a federal union. They continued into the Constitutional Convention, into the ratification debates, into the creation of political parties, and into virtually every major dispute that followed.

The challenge was therefore not to eliminate those differences but to construct a political system capable of holding them together.

That is a very different goal from making everyone agree.

A political union does not require every person within it to have the same religion, the same political philosophy, the same economic interests, or the same vision of the future. It requires a framework within which people with those differences can still recognize one another as members of the same political community. The disagreement can be fierce. The arguments can be deeply consequential. The participants can believe that the other side is profoundly mistaken. But the existence of disagreement does not, by itself, require the political community to dissolve.

In that sense, the one was the political union.

The many remained many.

And perhaps that is one of the most important ideas hidden in a phrase most Americans encounter without thinking much about it. The goal was never necessarily to create one American mind. It was to create one American political community capable of containing many minds.

That distinction gives us another way to understand the problem of cancel culture as well. If a free society is built around the idea that many people can belong to the same political community, then disagreement cannot automatically become evidence that one of those people no longer deserves a place within it. The question becomes not whether we can prevent people from disagreeing, but whether we can disagree without deciding that the other person must be excluded.

That is a much harder task. It is also much closer to the challenge contained in E Pluribus Unum.

Unity Is Not Uniformity

This distinction changes how we should think about almost everything we have discussed.

If unity requires uniformity, then disagreement is a threat to the nation. Every serious disagreement becomes evidence that something has gone wrong. Political opponents become obstacles to unity. Protest becomes divisiveness. Dissent becomes disloyalty. The natural response is to try to make everyone agree.

But that definition of unity creates a problem. In a country built from different communities, different beliefs, and competing ideas about government, complete agreement was never a realistic condition of political life. The existence of disagreement does not necessarily mean that the political community is falling apart. It may simply mean that the people within that community are doing what citizens in a

free society are expected to do: arguing over what their government should be, what their society should value, and how their country should move forward.

But if unity means agreeing to remain part of the same political community despite disagreement, then disagreement is not necessarily evidence of failure. It is something the system was designed to manage.

That distinction matters because disagreement and disunity are not necessarily the same thing. Two people can disagree about a political question and still recognize one another as fellow citizens. They can campaign against one another, vote differently, criticize one another's ideas, organize competing movements, and try to persuade their neighbors without concluding that the other person has forfeited a place in the country. The disagreement can be intense without becoming a rejection of the political relationship itself.

That does not mean every disagreement is harmless.

A democratic society can disagree about tax policy without threatening anyone's basic rights. It can debate the proper level of military spending without questioning whether the other side belongs in the country. It can argue about education, healthcare, environmental policy, or government regulation while still accepting that people who reach different conclusions remain fellow citizens. These disputes can matter enormously to the people involved. They can determine elections, change laws, reshape institutions, and affect people's lives. Yet they can still remain disputes within a shared political system.

That ability to disagree without immediately questioning the legitimacy of the other person is important. Democracy does not eliminate conflict; it gives conflict a place to go. Elections allow competing visions of government to be presented to voters. Legislatures allow competing interests to fight over laws. Courts provide a mechanism for resolving certain disputes. Protest allows citizens to express opposition outside formal government institutions. Journalism, organizing, petitioning, boycotts, and ordinary political argument provide still more ways for people to exert pressure and attempt to change minds.

None of these mechanisms guarantees agreement. They are not supposed to.

The point is that citizens can fight over the direction of the country without having to fight over whether the people on the other side are entitled to remain part of it.

But there are disagreements that go deeper.

Americans have historically disagreed about who should possess political rights, whether particular groups should be treated equally under the law, whether government should protect or restrict individual behavior, and whether certain people should be included within the political community at all. Those disagreements are harder because they are not simply arguments over policy. They are arguments over the boundaries of citizenship and freedom.

That distinction is important because not every political dispute can be reduced to a disagreement over preferences. There is a meaningful difference between arguing about the level of a tax and arguing about whether a person should have the same political rights as someone else. There is a difference between debating what government should regulate and debating whether government should be permitted to deny a particular group rights that others possess. In those circumstances, the disagreement

reaches beyond the question of which policy should win. It becomes a question about the rights and status of the people affected by that policy.

This creates a difficult balance.

We should not pretend that every disagreement is harmless simply because disagreement is a normal part of democracy. History contains disputes in which the consequences of political disagreement were very real, and in which the question was not merely what government should do but who would be protected by it. At the same time, recognizing that some disagreements involve fundamental questions does not mean that every political conflict should be described as an existential struggle in which compromise, opposition, or even ordinary political defeat becomes unacceptable.

The distinction matters because once every disagreement is treated as a threat to the existence of the country, the other side can begin to look less like a group of fellow citizens and more like an enemy that must be stopped. Political opposition becomes something more than opposition. Losing becomes something more than losing. And the ordinary mechanisms through which a democracy absorbs disagreement begin to look inadequate simply because they allow the other side to continue participating.

Unity, therefore, cannot mean that Americans stop disagreeing. It has to mean something harder: that Americans can disagree profoundly while still recognizing that they belong to the same political community.

And that brings us to the next question. If disagreement is not what holds Americans together, then what does?

What Holds a Country Together?

If Americans are not held together by agreement, then what holds them together? The Constitution is one answer. Laws are another. Institutions matter. Elections matter. Courts matter. Federalism matters. Shared history matters. Civic traditions matter. The willingness of political losers to accept legitimate outcomes matters. So does the willingness of political winners to recognize that they have not acquired unlimited power simply because they won.

Each of these things provides part of the structure within which Americans live together. The Constitution establishes a framework of government. Laws establish rules that apply to the people living under that government. Institutions provide places where disagreements can be heard, contested, and sometimes resolved. Elections provide a means for political power to change hands. Courts provide mechanisms for resolving certain disputes. Federalism allows political authority to be divided among different levels of government rather than concentrated entirely in one place.

But none of those things, by themselves, explains why people who disagree so profoundly continue to accept that they are members of the same political community.

Beneath all of those things is an even more basic idea: we agree to share the country.

That sounds almost embarrassingly simple.

It is not.

Sharing a political community means living alongside people whose beliefs may strike us as profoundly wrong. It means accepting that they have rights even when we dislike what they say. It means recognizing that they may vote differently, worship differently, protest differently, spend their money differently, raise their families differently, and understand America differently.

It does not require us to approve of those choices.

It requires us to recognize the person's right to exist within the political community.

That does not mean that citizens have to remain silent when they believe another person's actions or political ideas are harmful. Sharing a country does not eliminate criticism, opposition, protest, or political competition. It means that those activities take place within a larger understanding that the people involved remain part of the same political community.

The distinction may seem small, but it changes the nature of political conflict. If I believe that your political position is wrong, I can attempt to persuade you. If I believe your candidate should not win, I can vote against that candidate. If I believe a law is harmful, I can organize against it, protest it, challenge it in court, or work to change it. The disagreement can be intense without requiring me to conclude that you have no legitimate place in the country.

That may be one of the basic conditions of political coexistence.

A country cannot remain united by requiring everyone to think alike. It can remain united only if there is enough shared commitment to the political community itself that citizens are willing to continue living alongside people they believe are wrong.

And that brings us to the paradox at the heart of the American founding.

The Revolutionary Paradox

There is a paradox at the heart of the American founding.

The Revolution was an act of political rebellion against an existing government. The people who eventually created the United States were willing to reject political authority when they concluded that the existing system violated principles they considered fundamental. They did not believe that preserving political unity was more important than every other principle.

That creates an important qualification.

Unity cannot mean obedience.

A government cannot say, “You must remain united, therefore you must agree with us.”

If unity meant obedience to whoever happened to possess political authority, then disagreement itself would become a form of disunity. A government could demand conformity and describe resistance as a threat to national unity. Under that definition, the citizen's obligation would not be to participate in the political community but simply to obey whoever controlled it.

That is not the kind of unity the American founding describes.

The right to protest, criticize, organize, petition, publish, assemble, and challenge government authority is part of what makes political unity meaningful rather than coercive. If people are forced into silence, a country may look united from the outside while being deeply divided underneath. A population that cannot express disagreement has not necessarily achieved unity; it may simply have lost the ability to express its disagreement openly.

This is one of the tensions built into the American political experiment. The country requires enough common ground to function as one political community, but it also has to leave room for citizens to challenge the government and one another. It needs political order without demanding political conformity. It needs institutions strong enough to maintain the constitutional system while leaving citizens free to argue about what that system should mean and how it should operate.

That tension cannot really be eliminated.

In fact, attempting to eliminate it can create a new problem. If the government becomes the authority that decides which disagreements are legitimate, then unity can become another word for obedience. If citizens are told that challenging political authority is itself a threat to national unity, then the very mechanisms through which a free society corrects its government begin to disappear.

The American constitutional system therefore contains a tension that never completely disappears: How do you preserve a political community without requiring political conformity?

We have been wrestling with that question for almost 250 years.

The Civil War Complication

The Civil War complicates the idea even further.

If unity means that people with different beliefs agree to remain part of the same political community, then the Civil War presents the most difficult question imaginable: What happens when the disagreement becomes so fundamental that one part of the country no longer accepts the political union itself?

The Union ultimately rejected secession and fought to preserve the United States as one nation. But the war also demonstrates that there are limits to what political unity can mean. The federal government could not simply declare that the disagreement over slavery did not matter because preserving unity was the highest value. The question at the center of the conflict involved slavery, human freedom, constitutional authority, and the future structure of the nation itself.

There is a temptation, when discussing national unity, to treat unity as the highest political virtue. If staying together is always considered more important than everything else, then almost any injustice can be rationalized in the name of preserving the union. A country could theoretically demand that its citizens tolerate almost anything so long as the alternative is political division.

American history does not support such a simple definition. The issue involved human freedom and the constitutional structure of the country itself.

That means “unity” cannot be an excuse for tolerating every possible injustice. There are circumstances in which preserving the existing political arrangement can itself perpetuate a profound violation of rights. In those circumstances, the question cannot simply be, “How do we keep everyone together?” It also has to be, “Together under what conditions, and at whose expense?”

There is a difference between saying, “We disagree about how government should operate,” and saying, “We disagree about whether an entire category of people should possess basic rights.” The historical record shows that Americans have sometimes had to confront the possibility that preserving a political community requires changing the political system within it.

That does not make the Civil War an argument for treating every modern political dispute as a crisis of the same magnitude. Quite the opposite. The extraordinary circumstances of the Civil War are precisely why we should be careful about using it as a template for ordinary political disagreement. If every disagreement is described as another existential struggle over the survival of the country, then the language of fundamental crisis eventually loses its meaning.

The Civil War therefore gives us two lessons that have to be held together.

First, political unity matters. The dissolution of the Union produced catastrophic consequences, and the country that emerged from the conflict was profoundly changed. Second, unity by itself cannot answer every political question. There are circumstances in which the conditions under which people are being asked to remain united become more important than the mere fact of remaining together.

That leaves us with a difficult boundary.

How do we recognize when a disagreement genuinely concerns fundamental rights without turning every disagreement into a claim that the nation itself is at stake? How do we distinguish between political opponents who simply want the country to move in a different direction and conflicts over whether certain people are entitled to participate in the political community on equal terms?

The challenge is determining where that line is without turning every political disagreement into an existential one.

That may be one of the hardest problems in maintaining a free political community. A democracy has to be capable of absorbing enormous disagreement, but it also has to remain capable of recognizing when the disagreement concerns the rights that make democratic participation possible in the first place. The goal cannot be unity at any cost. Nor can it be the assumption that every disagreement justifies abandoning the common political community.

The harder task is learning how to tell the difference.

The Modern Version of the Question

That is where the present becomes uncomfortable.

Americans today disagree about many of the same broad questions that have appeared throughout the country's history: What is freedom? What should government control? What should government leave

alone? What rights belong to individuals? What obligations do citizens have to one another? What does equality require? What does the Constitution permit? What should America look like?

Those questions are not going away.

Nor should they.

A country in which citizens are free to think, speak, organize, vote, worship, protest, publish, and associate will inevitably contain serious disagreement. The existence of disagreement is therefore not, by itself, evidence that something has gone wrong. In a constitutional republic, disagreement is one of the things the political system has to be capable of accommodating.

The problem begins when we stop treating disagreement as something that can exist within the same political community and start treating it as proof that the other side is fundamentally illegitimate.

That is a much more serious development.

Once an opponent is no longer understood as a fellow citizen who happens to hold a different view, the objective of political conflict can begin to change. The question is no longer simply how to persuade that person, defeat their argument, win the election, change the law, or convince other citizens to reject their position. The question becomes how to prevent that person from participating at all.

That is the point at which the question we have been asking throughout this article becomes unavoidable: Who gets to decide who is allowed to participate?

If your answer to political disagreement is always, “Make them stop,” eventually the question becomes who gets to decide who must stop.

If your answer is government, you have created a powerful government authority that could eventually be used against you. The same government authority that can be used to suppress an idea you consider dangerous can, under different circumstances and different political leadership, be directed against an idea you consider essential. Government power does not automatically become safe simply because we trust the people exercising it today.

If your answer is private institutions, the problem takes a different form. Corporations, employers, universities, media organizations, professional organizations, online platforms, and other institutions may exercise significant power over people's ability to work, communicate, publish, organize, or participate in public life. That power is different from government power, and the legal rules surrounding it are different, but different does not mean irrelevant.

If your answer is the public, then you are relying on millions of individuals to decide what they will support, tolerate, purchase, watch, read, or reject. That is another form of power again. A person may decide not to buy a product. A group may organize a boycott. An audience may stop watching a program. Readers may stop subscribing to a publication. Citizens may decide that they no longer want to associate with a particular organization.

Those actions can have real consequences without being government coercion.

That distinction matters because one of the easiest mistakes in the modern cancel-culture debate is to treat every negative consequence for speech as though it were the same kind of power. It is not.

Government punishment, private institutional decisions, economic pressure, social criticism, and an individual's decision to walk away may all produce consequences, but they operate through different mechanisms and raise different questions.

The fact that they are different does not mean that every exercise of private or public pressure is harmless. It means that we have to identify what is actually happening before deciding what principle applies.

That brings us back to the question at the center of this entire discussion: What are we trying to protect?

Are we protecting someone from government punishment for expressing an unpopular political opinion? Are we protecting a private institution's ability to establish its own standards? Are we protecting consumers' ability to decide where they spend their money? Are we protecting an individual's freedom to refuse an association? Are we protecting someone's ability to participate in public life without being subjected to threats or violence?

Those are different questions.

And because they are different questions, they cannot all have the same answer.

This is where the historical discussion becomes relevant to the present. Americans have repeatedly used political pressure, economic pressure, public criticism, protest, boycotts, institutional authority, and government power in conflicts over what the country should be. Sometimes those mechanisms have been used to challenge genuine injustice. Sometimes they have been used to enforce conformity. Sometimes they have expanded the ability of people to participate in American life. Sometimes they have narrowed it.

The mechanism matters because power matters.

And power matters because eventually someone has to decide where the line is.

We have spent much of this article examining why that distinction matters.

The United States Has Always Been a Negotiation

Perhaps the most honest way to describe American unity is not as agreement but as negotiation.

That may sound like a strange way to describe a country. We tend to think of negotiation as something that happens when two sides are trying to reach a settlement: diplomats negotiating a treaty, legislators negotiating a bill, lawyers negotiating an agreement, or two people trying to resolve a dispute. But a constitutional republic is, in many respects, a permanent negotiation. Millions of people with different interests, beliefs, histories, priorities, and ideas about government are required to share the same political community.

We negotiate with people we disagree with because we have no choice but to share the same political space. We negotiate through elections, legislation, courts, protest, journalism, organizing, economic pressure, and ordinary conversation. We negotiate by persuading other people to change their minds, by

accepting that sometimes they will not, and by using established institutions to determine what happens when disagreement cannot be resolved through persuasion alone.

Sometimes the negotiations fail. Sometimes they take decades. Sometimes they produce constitutional change. Sometimes they produce political compromises that satisfy almost nobody completely. Sometimes they produce movements that fundamentally alter how Americans understand the country. And sometimes they produce conflict that leaves permanent scars.

But negotiation remains preferable to the alternative.

The alternative is not necessarily peace. It is the belief that disagreement itself is unacceptable and that the opposing side must therefore be removed from the political community rather than defeated within it.

That is a very different understanding of political conflict. If the purpose of political participation is to eliminate the people who disagree with us, then every election becomes more than an argument over who should govern. Every election becomes a struggle over whether the other side should continue to have a legitimate place in American public life. Every political victory becomes an opportunity to consolidate power, and every political defeat becomes evidence that something must be done to prevent the other side from returning.

That is not negotiation. It is political conflict without an accepted stopping point.

Democratic politics requires something more difficult. It requires the willingness to accept that the people who disagree with you are going to remain. They may lose an election and run again. They may lose a legislative battle and organize for the next one. They may lose a public argument and continue making it. They may persuade their neighbors, change public opinion, build a movement, and eventually win.

That possibility is not a defect in the system. It is part of the system.

This is also why political disagreement cannot be understood solely in terms of whether one side is right or wrong. Of course Americans believe some political positions are right and others are wrong. That is the nature of political argument. The important question is whether believing your position is correct gives you the authority to deny the other side the ability to participate.

It does not automatically do so.

You can believe another person's political philosophy is deeply mistaken and still recognize their right to hold it. You can campaign against their candidate without believing that their supporters are illegitimate citizens. You can oppose their legislation without believing that they have forfeited their right to participate in the political process. You can criticize their arguments, boycott their organization, refuse to associate with them, or attempt to persuade others to do the same without necessarily concluding that they should be prevented from existing within the political community.

That distinction brings us back to the central problem of cancel culture.

The issue is not whether Americans are allowed to disagree. They obviously are. The issue is what happens after the disagreement.

Do we argue? Do we persuade? Do we organize? Do we vote? Do we protest? Do we boycott? Do we criticize? Or do we eventually decide that the other person should no longer be permitted to participate? Those choices represent different responses to the same basic fact: we have to live together.

The United States cannot eliminate disagreement without eliminating much of what makes it a free political community. The country contains people who disagree about religion, economics, race, government, individual liberty, social policy, constitutional interpretation, foreign policy, and the proper direction of the country. There is no realistic version of American unity in which all of those differences disappear.

The question is therefore not how to eliminate disagreement. The question is whether Americans can develop enough political and civic restraint to live with it.

That does not mean accepting every idea as equally valid. It does not mean refusing to criticize anyone. It does not mean abandoning political movements, social pressure, boycotts, protests, or efforts to change institutions. Those are all part of the ways citizens exercise power.

It means recognizing the difference between defeating an idea and eliminating the person who holds it.

A political argument can be won. A political movement can be defeated. A candidate can lose. A company can lose customers. A publication can lose readers. A speaker can lose an audience. An institution can change its policies. But the people involved remain part of the country. That may be one of the least satisfying realities of democracy.

We do not get to permanently finish the argument.

The people we disagree with do not disappear after we defeat them. They remain our neighbors, coworkers, fellow voters, relatives, journalists, students, teachers, business owners, activists, public officials, and citizens. They will continue making arguments we dislike. They will continue organizing around causes we oppose. And sometimes, despite our best efforts, they will persuade other people.

That is what political freedom looks like when it is shared rather than possessed by only one side.

The alternative is the belief that the only legitimate America is the America that looks the way I believe it should look. Once we reach that point, United States becomes an ironic name.

There is nothing particularly united about a country in which every political faction believes that only its version of America is legitimate. The challenge is not to make America uniform.

It is to determine whether Americans can continue negotiating with one another while remaining many different people within one country.

Maybe the Name Was Always a Challenge

Perhaps the founders were not describing a finished achievement when they called the country the United States.

Perhaps they were describing an ongoing project.

The states were united because they had chosen to form a union. The people were united politically because they had agreed to live under a common constitutional structure. That did not eliminate their differences. It created a framework within which those differences could exist.

The name itself therefore contains a challenge. Can many become one without ceasing to be many? That may be one of the central questions of the American experiment.

It is also the question underneath cancel culture, protest, boycotts, censorship debates, political violence, polarization, and the endless arguments over who is destroying America.

We keep asking how to make the other side stop. Perhaps we should sometimes ask a different question:

How do we continue living together when we cannot make the other side stop?

That question leads directly into one of the oldest tensions in American political thought—the boundary between the individual and the state, between public authority and private life, and between the freedom to live according to your own conscience and the responsibility not to violate someone else's rights.

In other words, if *E Pluribus Unum* means that many different people can become one political community, then we need to understand what that community is actually entitled to demand from the individual.

And that brings us to something Higher Ideals has returned to before:

the right to leave people alone.

Maybe “United” Never Meant Agreement.

Maybe we have been asking the wrong question.

For most of American history, the country has been described as divided whenever Americans have disagreed strongly enough to make the disagreement uncomfortable. We say the country is divided over politics, divided over religion, divided over race, divided over culture, divided over economics, and divided over what freedom means. The language suggests that unity is the normal condition and disagreement is the interruption. But the historical record suggests almost the opposite: disagreement is normal, and the remarkable thing is that Americans have repeatedly managed to remain one political community despite it.

That is a very different definition of unity.

What Does “United” Actually Require?

Imagine two neighbors who agree on almost nothing. They vote differently, have different religious beliefs, and have completely different ideas about what government should do. One supports a policy the other considers disastrous, and they may even dislike one another. Are they capable of living next door to each other? Of course they are. They do not need political agreement to share a street; they need rules governing what each person may do to the other, some understanding of property and

personal safety, and a recognition that each person's freedom has boundaries where another person's rights begin.

A constitutional republic operates on a much larger version of the same principle. The purpose of a political system is not necessarily to make its citizens agree. It is to establish the rules under which people who do not agree can live together.

That distinction may be one of the most important ideas in this entire article.

We Have Never Been One Thing

The United States has never been culturally, religiously, economically, or politically uniform. The original colonies themselves were different from one another, with different economies, religious traditions, relationships with slavery, and political cultures. Even during the Revolution, Americans disagreed over independence, loyalty to Britain, the proper structure of government, and what the new country should become.

The Constitution did not erase those differences. It created a framework for managing them. That framework has changed repeatedly because Americans have repeatedly fought over what it should mean. The Bill of Rights was added because Americans disagreed about the powers of the new federal government; the Civil War and Reconstruction amendments fundamentally altered the constitutional order; the expansion of voting rights changed who could participate in the political system; and later civil-rights legislation and constitutional interpretation changed how the nation understood equality.

The United States has therefore never been a finished product. It has been an argument.

The Argument Is the Country

That may sound strange, but consider what happens when Americans disagree. They write, protest, publish newspapers, organize, boycott, petition, sue, run for office, vote, change laws, and sometimes seek to amend the Constitution. They sometimes refuse to obey laws they believe are unjust, while others defend those laws and challenge the protesters. And sometimes, tragically, Americans fight.

The argument itself is not evidence that the American system has failed. Much of the argument is the American system operating. A democracy is supposed to provide citizens with peaceful mechanisms for competing over ideas, interests, rights, and political power.

The problem comes when one side concludes that the argument should end because the other side should no longer be permitted to participate. That is when disagreement begins turning into something else.

There Is a Difference Between Winning and Eliminating

Political competition requires winners and losers. That sounds obvious, but it has a surprisingly important implication: losing is supposed to be temporary. A political movement can lose an election and organize for the next one; a bill can fail and be introduced again; a Supreme Court decision can be challenged through later cases, legislation, constitutional amendment, or changing legal doctrine; and a social movement can lose public support and attempt to persuade people again.

The defeated side remains.

That is what makes political competition different from war. In war, the objective is to defeat the enemy's ability to continue fighting. In democratic politics, the objective is supposed to be winning enough support to exercise political authority within the rules of the system. Those are profoundly different goals, and when political actors begin treating ordinary political opponents as enemies who must be permanently neutralized, democracy becomes harder to sustain.

But What About Injustice?

Here is where this argument can become too simplistic if we are not careful. “Just live and let live” cannot be the answer to every political conflict. There have been times in American history when leaving people alone meant leaving an existing injustice untouched. Slavery is the obvious example; segregation is another; women being denied the vote was another. A philosophy of individual liberty cannot simply become an excuse for ignoring circumstances in which one person's freedom depends upon denying another person's basic rights.

That is why the Right to Leave People Alone has never been intended as an absolute command to government or society to never interfere with anyone. It is a principle about restraint. It asks us to begin with the assumption that people should generally be free to live, believe, speak, associate, and make personal choices without unnecessary interference, while recognizing that this freedom has a boundary: your freedom does not include the right to violate someone else's rights.

That boundary is essential. Without it, “leave me alone” could become a justification for allowing one person to harm another. With it, the principle becomes something more useful: a presumption in favor of personal liberty combined with a recognition that liberty exists alongside the rights of other people.

The Founding and the Private Sphere

This concern with the private sphere is deeply embedded in American constitutional structure. The First Amendment protects freedoms of religion, speech, press, assembly, and petition against government interference. The Third Amendment restricts the quartering of soldiers in private homes without the owner's consent in peacetime and under specified legal conditions in wartime. The Fourth Amendment protects people against unreasonable searches and seizures and places particular protections around their persons, houses, papers, and effects.

These amendments are not all expressions of one single doctrine called the “right to be left alone.” They address different constitutional problems and have different legal histories. But together, they reflect something important about the American constitutional tradition: government power was not supposed to have unlimited access to every part of a person's life.

That principle matters in an article about cancel culture because cancel culture is fundamentally about power. Who gets to decide what another person may say? Who gets to decide where they may work, which institutions will associate with them, or whether they can participate in public life? And, most importantly, who has the authority to enforce that decision? Those questions cannot all be answered the same way.

Private Power Is Still Power

It is tempting to think that the only meaningful threat to liberty comes from government. American constitutional law makes an important distinction between government action and private action, and

the First Amendment generally constrains government rather than private individuals or private organizations. A private employer, publisher, university, website, or business can therefore have forms of decision-making authority that the government does not possess.

That does not make private power irrelevant. If thousands of people pressure a company to fire an employee, the government is not necessarily censoring that employee. If a television network cancels a program, that is not automatically government censorship. If consumers stop buying a product, that is not government punishment. The consequences can nevertheless be enormous, which is why the question cannot simply be, “Is this censorship?”

Sometimes the more precise question is: Who is exercising power, what kind of power is it, and what rules govern that power? That question gives us a much better way to understand the modern world.

A Real-Time Test

There is a useful way to see why the distinction between government power and private power matters: sometimes the distinction stops being theoretical.

As this article is being written, a dispute over access to the White House is putting that question directly into the public arena. In September 2026, President Donald Trump announced that CNN, MS NOW, and Politico would be barred from the White House. Reporters for the three organizations were subsequently denied access to the White House grounds and had their press credentials confiscated. The organizations then sued the administration, arguing that the action violated their First Amendment rights.

The administration has taken the position that the First Amendment protects the outlets' ability to publish but does not give them an automatic right to a White House hard pass, briefing-room seat, or position in the press pool. A federal judge subsequently ordered the administration to immediately restore the outlets' access. The administration did not immediately comply: reporters from the three organizations were initially turned away the following morning despite the court's order, prompting the outlets to seek an emergency hearing. The White House eventually restored their access later that morning. But the dispute did not end there. The administration then barred CNN from traveling with President Trump on Air Force One while the network was scheduled to serve as the rotating television pool.[Reuters: White House press-access litigation (Oct. 8, 2026)]

The move raised a further question: was the administration exercising legitimate control over access to the president, or was it using governmental authority to exclude a news organization because of its reporting? The legal dispute remains ongoing.

The episode raised another question as well: what does it mean when a federal court orders the government to restore access and the government does not immediately comply? And when the administration subsequently excludes CNN from traveling with the president as part of the rotating television pool, is that simply another exercise of legitimate control over access to the president, or does it cross the line into government overreach?[AP: DOJ inquiry into TV pool suspension (Oct. 11, 2026)]

Those questions remain part of the litigation and cannot be settled by political preference. What matters for this discussion is the underlying principle: government authority is not unlimited simply because

the government is the institution exercising it. The same action that might be entirely ordinary when taken by a private institution can become constitutionally significant when taken by the government, because government possesses coercive powers that private citizens and organizations do not.

The response from the other television networks created a very different exercise of power. When the White House prevented CNN from carrying out its pool duties, the other major networks did not simply choose another organization to take CNN's place. Instead, the networks suspended their participation in the television pool, meaning that the administration's actions temporarily resulted in less television coverage of the president's public activities. They were not exercising government authority. They were deciding whether and how to use their own resources and institutional cooperation.

In ordinary language, that is a boycott: a group of private institutions deciding that they will withhold their participation rather than accept the terms being imposed upon them. It may be criticized. It may be ineffective. It may inconvenience the public. It may even raise legitimate questions about whether news organizations should use their collective position this way. But it is still fundamentally different from the government restricting those organizations' access through the authority of public office. One is private power being exercised collectively. The other is public power being exercised coercively.

The context matters here because the president himself has publicly connected the restrictions to the outlets' coverage. Trump has described CNN, MS NOW, and Politico as sources of what he considers false or unfavorable reporting, and has repeatedly criticized their coverage of his administration. That does not by itself resolve the constitutional question, but it removes the need to speculate about whether the government's dissatisfaction with the press was merely incidental to the restrictions. The president has made clear that the content of the reporting was part of the dispute.

The administration responded by creating another channel through which it could communicate directly with the public. In September, the White House launched “Trump TV,” a 24/7 digital stream featuring presidential and administration events. The timing made the move particularly significant: the government had restricted access for several news organizations whose reporting the president had publicly criticized, the major television networks had responded by suspending their pool coverage, and the administration then provided its own continuous stream of presidential footage. The government is certainly entitled to communicate with the public and to present its own account of events. But when government restricts access for journalists whose reporting it dislikes and then provides its own channel of communication, a different question arises: is the government simply exercising its own ability to speak, or is it using governmental power to suppress competing speech and replace it with its own? That distinction goes directly to the line between government authority and the rights of the people. Source: NPR report, September 22, 2026[White House: Trump TV announcement] [NPR: Trump TV and White House media-ban reporting] [Reuters: October 8 press-access hearing] [Reuters: press-access litigation, Oct. 8, 2026] [AP: DOJ inquiry, Oct. 11, 2026]

The media boycott did not produce a permanent withdrawal from the television pool. Within days, the networks began moving toward resuming shared pool coverage, even as the dispute over CNN's participation continued. That matters too. Private institutions can organize, withdraw cooperation, apply pressure, reconsider their strategy, and change course. Their power can be substantial without being governmental power.

This is precisely the kind of situation in which the word “cancel” can become too imprecise to be useful.

A person deciding not to watch CNN is exercising personal choice. A group of consumers organizing a boycott against a media company is exercising collective economic pressure. A private company deciding that it does not want to advertise with CNN is exercising private institutional power. None of those actions is the same thing as the government restricting a news organization's access to a government-controlled facility because of a dispute over its reporting.

The mechanism matters because the source of the power matters.

The First Amendment states that “Congress shall make no law” abridging the freedom of speech or of the press. Modern constitutional doctrine extends that protection to government officials and agencies more broadly. It does not generally impose the same First Amendment restrictions on private individuals, private employers, private universities, private businesses, or private media organizations. [Supreme Court: NRA v. Vullo (2024)] Source: Constitution Annotated: First Amendment Case analysis: Constitution Annotated: NRA v. Vullo [Supreme Court opinion: NRA v. Vullo]

That distinction is not a technicality.

Imagine the government telling a newspaper that it may continue publishing but that its reporters will no longer be permitted access to government facilities because officials dislike the newspaper's coverage. That is fundamentally different from a private citizen saying, “I don't trust this newspaper, so I won't read it.” It is also different from a private company deciding, “We don't want our advertising next to this newspaper's content.” The consequences may be significant in all three situations, but the authority behind the decision is different.

And that is exactly why this current dispute is worth examining.

The question is not simply whether CNN, MS NOW, or Politico have produced reporting that the president considers unfair. Nor is the question whether private citizens should be allowed to criticize those organizations, stop watching them, boycott them, or encourage other people to do the same. Those are all questions that belong to the realm of private choice and public persuasion.

The constitutional question is narrower and more specific: what authority does the government have to determine which journalists may have access to the government while performing the work of covering it, and may that authority be exercised because officials object to the journalists' reporting?

That is a very different question from whether anyone has a right to force other people to consume a particular news organization's work.

It is also why the lawsuit matters even before a court reaches a final conclusion.

The dispute gives us a real-time example of the distinction this article has been making throughout its examination of cancel culture. Pressure can come from individuals. It can come from organized groups. It can come from consumers. It can come from employers, universities, publishers, platforms, corporations, and other private institutions. And it can come from government.

Those forms of pressure should not automatically be treated as interchangeable simply because the word “cancel” can be applied to all of them.

If a citizen says, “I don't want to watch this,” that citizen is exercising a choice.

If a group says, “We don't want to support this, and we want other people to reconsider their support,” that is advocacy.

If a private institution says, “We have decided not to associate with this person or organization,” that is private institutional power, subject to whatever laws and contractual obligations apply.

But when the government becomes the actor, the constitutional analysis changes. That does not automatically tell us the outcome of every particular dispute. It tells us which set of questions we have to ask.

Who is exercising the power? What authority does that actor possess? What is the person or organization being prevented from doing? Why is the action being taken? What right is implicated?

And what rules limit the authority being exercised? Those questions bring us back to the distinction at the heart of this article. Cancel culture is not one single mechanism. It is a broad label applied to a collection of actions that can look superficially similar while being constitutionally and politically very different.

The difference between a citizen refusing to watch a news program and the government restricting a journalist's access to the government is not merely a difference in degree.

It is a difference in who has the power to act. And that is why, when we talk about cancellation, we have to ask not simply “What happened to this person?” but “Who did it, and what authority did they have to do it?”

The Right to Walk Away

There is another side to this principle that we have already encountered throughout the article. Leaving someone alone also means having the freedom to walk away. You do not have to buy the product, watch the show, listen to the speaker, attend the event, follow the account, support the artist, or work for the company. You can decide that you want nothing to do with something you find objectionable, and that decision is itself a form of freedom.

That may seem obvious, but it is an important part of the cancel-culture debate because participation is not something that other people are automatically entitled to demand from us. A person can decide that a particular speaker is offensive and leave the event. A consumer can decide that a company no longer reflects their values and stop buying its products. A viewer can stop watching a television program. A reader can stop subscribing to a publication. An employee can decide to leave a workplace. These choices may have consequences for the person or institution on the receiving end, but the person making the choice is exercising their own freedom.

The same principle applies to association. We are not required to associate with everyone whose beliefs we tolerate. A person can disagree with a political movement and refuse to join it. A business can decide whom it wants to sponsor, subject to applicable law. A private organization can establish rules

governing membership or participation, again subject to applicable law. A citizen can simply say, “I want no part of this,” and walk away.

That is not necessarily cancellation in the coercive sense. Sometimes it is simply liberty. This distinction becomes particularly important because public discussion can collapse very different actions into the same word. If someone refuses to watch a movie because they dislike the politics of an actor, that is a personal decision. If thousands of people independently decide not to watch the movie, the economic consequences may be substantial, but the underlying mechanism is still voluntary choice. If those people organize a boycott and ask others to join them, they have moved from individual choice into collective political or economic pressure, but they are still asking other people to make their own decisions.

The line changes when the objective becomes preventing other people from exercising their own choices.

There is a significant difference between saying, “I will not participate,” and saying, “You must not participate either.” That difference is at the heart of the Right to Leave People Alone.

A person who walks away is making a decision about their own participation. A person who attempts to prevent everyone else from participating is making a decision about somebody else's freedom. Those two actions can arise from the same disagreement and even use similar language, but they involve fundamentally different claims of authority.

This is why the question of mechanism matters so much.

Suppose someone hears a political speaker whose views they find offensive. They can leave the room. They can refuse to buy the speaker's book. They can criticize the speech afterward. They can write an article explaining why they believe the speaker is wrong. They can persuade friends not to attend the next event. They can organize a peaceful demonstration outside the venue. They can ask the organization hosting the speaker not to invite that person again.

Those are all different forms of response, and some may be more consequential than others. But they share an important characteristic: they generally rely on the responding person's own choices or on persuasion directed toward other people who remain free to make their own choices.

Now change the mechanism.

Imagine demanding that the government prohibit the speaker from appearing. Imagine using government authority to punish the speaker because officials dislike the content of the speech. Imagine threatening violence against people who attend the event. Imagine physically preventing the audience from entering.

The underlying disagreement has not changed. The mechanism has.

That is why it is not enough to ask whether someone was “canceled.” We have to ask what actually happened. Was someone criticized? Was someone boycotted? Was a private contract terminated? Was someone removed from a private organization? Was someone denied a government benefit? Was someone prosecuted? Was someone threatened? Was someone physically prevented from participating? Was government authority involved?

Those are not interchangeable events. They can have very different implications for individual liberty.

This also helps explain why the freedom to walk away is not merely a defensive principle. It is a positive form of power. Every person has some ability to decide where their money goes, what they watch, what they read, whom they associate with, what organizations they join, and which causes they support. A free society gives people considerable room to make those decisions for themselves.

That freedom can produce outcomes that someone else considers unfair. A newspaper may lose subscribers. A business may lose customers. An artist may lose an audience. A political organization may lose donors. A university may lose applicants. A speaker may find fewer people willing to host an event.

None of those outcomes is automatically evidence that someone's rights have been violated.

At the same time, neither is the fact that an action is voluntary enough to make every consequence harmless. Collective pressure can become enormous. A coordinated campaign can damage someone's reputation, employment, livelihood, or ability to participate in public life. False accusations can spread rapidly. Threats can transform what appears to be voluntary pressure into something much more coercive. Private institutions can possess enormous power over people's lives even when government is not involved.

That is why this article has resisted the temptation to divide the world into a simple choice between “free speech” and “cancel culture.” The real world is considerably more complicated.

The important question is not whether people are allowed to respond to speech. They are. The question is what they are entitled to do in response, what other people are entitled to do in response, and where the exercise of one person's freedom begins to interfere with another person's rights.

The Right to Leave People Alone therefore has a second half that is just as important as the first. You have the right to walk away. So does everyone else. You can refuse to watch. Someone else can choose to watch. You can refuse to buy. Someone else can choose to buy. You can refuse to associate. Someone else can choose to associate. You can argue that a person should not be given a platform. Someone else can decide to give them one.

You can attempt to persuade them otherwise. They can say no.

That can be frustrating. It can even feel intolerable when we believe the other person's choice supports something deeply wrong. But the existence of another person's freedom means that we do not get to control every decision simply because we believe our reasons are better.

This is where the principle becomes genuinely difficult. If we believe in the freedom to walk away only when we are the ones walking away, then we do not really have a principle. We have a preference.

The Consistency Test requires something harder: applying the same basic respect for individual choice when someone else is making a decision we strongly dislike.

That does not mean abandoning criticism. It does not mean treating every choice as morally equivalent. It does not mean refusing to organize, protest, boycott, persuade, or demand change. It means

recognizing that persuasion and coercion are not the same thing, and that exercising your freedom does not automatically give you authority over someone else's.

The right to walk away is therefore not a retreat from civic participation. It is part of civic participation. Sometimes the most powerful thing a person can say is, “I will not participate.”

And sometimes the most important question is whether we are willing to leave other people free to make the opposite choice. That is where the principle becomes more than a slogan.

It becomes a test of whether we actually believe people should be left alone.

The Question of Boundaries

This is where the article's argument becomes less comfortable than the usual debate over cancel culture. It is relatively easy to defend freedom when the person exercising it is saying something we agree with, and it is equally easy to condemn interference when the person being interfered with is someone we like. The harder question comes when the positions are reversed. What happens when we strongly dislike what someone is doing, believe their conduct is harmful, and still have to determine whether we have the right to interfere with it?

There are circumstances in which collective pressure is entirely legitimate. There are circumstances in which it can become destructive. There are circumstances in which government intervention is necessary to protect someone's rights, and circumstances in which government intervention itself becomes the threat to liberty. There are circumstances in which a private institution should be free to establish its own standards, and circumstances in which private power can become so concentrated that society begins asking legitimate questions about its consequences. These situations can look remarkably similar from the outside while involving completely different kinds of authority.

That is why the question cannot simply be, “Was someone canceled?” That phrase tells us very little by itself.

It does not tell us who acted. It does not tell us what authority they possessed. It does not tell us whether the action was voluntary or coercive. It does not tell us whether a law was broken, whether a contract was terminated, whether consumers exercised their purchasing power, whether an institution enforced its own rules, whether someone was threatened, or whether government authority was used.

The word “cancel” can describe all of those things in ordinary conversation, but the distinctions between them are precisely what matter when we are trying to understand questions of liberty and power.

There is no single sentence that resolves all of these situations. But there is a useful starting point: What right are you trying to protect, and whose right are you asking someone else to surrender? That question forces us to move beyond whether we like the person involved. It asks us to identify the actual principle at stake.

Suppose someone says something you find deeply offensive. You may believe they are wrong. You may criticize them. You may argue against them. You may ask others not to support them. You may

refuse to associate with them. You may decide not to buy their work or attend their events. Depending on the circumstances, you may even organize other people around the same decision.

But what exactly are you asking the other person to give up? Are you asking them to lose your business? Your attention? Your association? Your support?

Or are you asking them to lose their job, their ability to speak, their legal rights, their access to government services, or their physical safety?

Those are not necessarily the same thing.

The same principle applies in the other direction. If someone claims that their freedom of expression gives them a right to force a private organization to publish their work, that claim requires examination too. Freedom from government censorship is not automatically a guarantee that another private person or institution must provide a platform. Likewise, the freedom to criticize a company does not automatically create a right to use that company's property or resources however one wishes.

Rights have boundaries. So does power.

The difficulty is that Americans often recognize those boundaries only when they protect us personally. We may defend the right of a private organization to reject someone when we agree with the organization's decision, then describe the same authority as dangerous when the organization rejects someone whose views we support. We may defend a boycott when it targets a company we dislike, then describe an opposing boycott as illegitimate when it threatens a company we support.

That is precisely where the Consistency Test becomes useful. If the principle is legitimate, it should not depend entirely upon whether the person exercising it is on our side.

That does not mean every use of private power is equally justified. It means we should be able to explain why one use of power is different from another. If our only explanation is that we approve of one and disapprove of the other, then we have not established a principle. We have established a preference.

The Right to Leave People Alone therefore requires more than simply defending personal freedom in the abstract. It requires us to recognize that other people possess freedom too. Sometimes that means accepting a decision we strongly dislike. Sometimes it means allowing an organization to make a decision we believe is unfair. Sometimes it means accepting the consequences of other people's choices. And sometimes it means recognizing that another person's conduct has crossed the boundary where intervention is justified because someone else's rights are being violated.

That boundary will not always be obvious.

In fact, some of the hardest political questions exist precisely because reasonable people can disagree about where the boundary should be drawn. But disagreement over the boundary is different from pretending that no boundary exists. The task is not to create a world in which nobody ever interferes with anyone else. That world is impossible. The task is to determine which forms of interference are justified, who has the authority to impose them, and what limits should exist on that authority.

That brings us back to the central question running through this entire article: Who has the power to act, and what gives them that power?

A citizen exercising a personal choice is not the same as a government exercising sovereign authority. A consumer boycott is not the same as a criminal prosecution. A private organization's membership decision is not the same as a law. A public criticism is not the same as a physical threat.

The boundaries matter because liberty depends not only on what happens, but on how it happens. And once we begin looking at the question that way, the debate over cancel culture becomes much less about deciding who deserves to be canceled and much more about understanding the competing rights and sources of power involved.

That is a harder conversation. It is also a more useful one.

How Much of Your Neighbor's Life Belongs to You?

This is where the argument stops being abstract. It is easy to defend liberty when we are talking about ourselves: we want the freedom to speak, worship, associate, work, spend our money, raise our families, and make personal choices without unnecessary interference. We become considerably less enthusiastic about that same freedom when the person exercising it is someone whose beliefs we find offensive or whose choices we believe are harmful. That is the real test of a principle, because the person who agrees with you does not require much tolerance; the person who disagrees with you does.

A principle of liberty has very little value if it only protects people we consider deserving of liberty. The harder case is the person whose opinions make us angry, whose political choices we cannot understand, or whose values seem completely incompatible with our own. If our instinct is that *our* freedom deserves protection while *their* freedom can be restricted because we disapprove of them, then we have not really established a principle of individual liberty. We have established a hierarchy in which liberty depends upon approval.

That is precisely the temptation the Right to Leave People Alone is supposed to resist.

The Neighbor Problem

Go back to the hypothetical neighbor. You know what they believe, how they vote, and what they think about abortion, guns, religion, immigration, taxes, race, foreign policy, or whatever issue matters most to you. Perhaps you have seen the political sign in their yard or the post they made online. Perhaps you have heard them express an opinion that you consider not merely wrong but morally repugnant.

What do you actually have a right to control?

You have a right to protect yourself from violence. You have a right to seek legal protection when someone threatens you or violates your rights. You have the right to participate in politics, persuade others, decide what you personally support, determine what you purchase, choose what you watch, and decide which organizations you join, subject to applicable law.

But the fact that another person holds an opinion you dislike does not, by itself, give you ownership over that person's life.

That sounds obvious when stated that way. Yet much of the modern argument over cancel culture begins with a much less obvious assumption: that discovering something objectionable about another person creates some kind of claim over what happens to them next. We learn where someone stands politically and immediately begin asking whether they should lose their job. We discover that an actor, musician, professor, executive, journalist, or ordinary citizen holds an unpopular opinion and begin discussing whether that person should still have a platform. Sometimes the discussion remains at the level of criticism. Sometimes it moves toward pressure on an institution. Sometimes it moves further still.

The important question is not whether we are permitted to dislike the person. Of course we are. The question is what that dislike entitles us to do.

There is a fundamental difference between discovering that your neighbor supports a political position you oppose and discovering that your neighbor is actively violating your rights. The first is a disagreement. The second may require intervention. Between those two points lies an enormous amount of territory, and that territory is where judgment becomes necessary.

Suppose your neighbor puts a political sign in the yard supporting a candidate you believe would be disastrous for the country. You can dislike the sign. You can tell your friends why you dislike it. You can put up your own sign. You can knock on doors for the opposing candidate. You can write about the election. You can vote. You can try to persuade your neighbor to change their mind.

But what would give you the authority to decide that your neighbor should no longer be allowed to express that political preference?

The answer cannot simply be, “Because I believe they are wrong.” If it were, then the same principle would be available to your neighbor.

They could decide that your political beliefs are dangerous and therefore that you should lose your own ability to participate. They could demand that your employer punish you. They could pressure institutions to exclude you. They could insist that your political activity makes you unworthy of participation in the community.

That is where the Consistency Test becomes unavoidable. A free society cannot be built around the assumption that everyone will use power only when they agree with us. We have to build rules that remain meaningful when the people exercising them are our political opponents. Otherwise, the protections we defend today can become the instruments we fear tomorrow.

We Are Constantly Tempted to Expand the Boundary

Consider how often Americans use political disagreement to justify decisions about people who have nothing directly to do with the original dispute. An actor makes a political statement, and people decide they will never watch the actor's movies again. A musician expresses an opinion, and listeners decide they will stop buying the music. A company takes a political position, and consumers organize a boycott. A professor makes a controversial statement, and students demand disciplinary action. An

employee expresses an opinion outside of work, and coworkers or customers demand that the employer punish the employee.

These examples may look similar because they all begin with disagreement. But the actions that follow can be very different.

The person who stops watching a movie is making a decision about their own participation. The person who organizes a boycott is attempting to persuade other people to make the same decision. The person who demands that an employer fire someone is attempting to influence an institution's decision about another person's employment. The person who asks the government to punish someone is invoking the authority of the state.

Those are different exercises of power.

Some of these responses are ordinary exercises of individual or collective choice. Others can raise questions about institutional policy, employment law, or coercion. A boycott may be an entirely lawful expression of political pressure while a threat against an employee's family is something very different. A private organization may have legitimate reasons for establishing standards for its members while a government agency faces constitutional restrictions that do not apply in exactly the same way to a private organization.

The important point is that the progression from disagreement to consequence is not automatic. At each stage, we should ask what changed.

Did we merely change our own behavior? Did we persuade someone else to change theirs? Did an institution make a decision using its own authority? Did someone use coercion? Did government power become involved? Did someone's legally protected rights become implicated?

Those questions do not produce an automatic answer in every case. They do something more useful: they force us to identify the actual boundary we are discussing.

And that matters because the danger in cancel-culture arguments is not simply that people sometimes go too far. It is that we can become so focused on the person we believe deserves consequences that we stop examining the power being used to impose them.

A person can be deeply wrong and still possess rights. A company can make a decision we believe is unfair without becoming the government. A citizen can organize an aggressive boycott without possessing sovereign authority.

A government can have a legitimate reason to regulate conduct without having unlimited authority to regulate belief or expression. The identity of the person involved does not answer these questions for us.

The mechanism does. And once we recognize that, the neighbor becomes more than a hypothetical example. The neighbor is a reminder that the people whose freedom we are tempted to restrict are not abstract political opponents. They are people who live in the same country we do, under the same constitutional system, with the same basic claim to the protections of that system.

The question is not whether we will ever disagree with them. We will. The question is whether disagreement alone gives us the right to decide how much of their lives they are allowed to keep.

There is a common thread running through all of these examples. Something happens in one part of a person's life, and we become tempted to make that event matter in every other part of their life. The actor's political opinion becomes a reason to reject the movie. The musician's political position becomes a reason to reject the music. The employee's statement becomes a reason to question the person's employment. The professor's controversial comment becomes a reason to question whether that person should continue teaching. Sometimes those connections may be legitimate. Sometimes they may be completely unrelated.

That distinction matters.

People do not exist in only one role. The same person can be a citizen, an employee, a parent, a neighbor, a consumer, a religious participant, a professional, a voter, and a private individual. We naturally encounter those different parts of a person's life at the same time, especially in an age when social media makes it possible to move almost instantly from someone's professional identity to their political opinions to their personal life. The fact that we can see all of those things, however, does not necessarily mean that we are entitled to treat all of them as interchangeable.

An employee's political statement outside the workplace may have nothing to do with the employee's ability to perform the job. In another case, the employee's conduct may directly affect the responsibilities of the position or violate an established workplace rule. A professor's political opinion may have nothing to do with the quality of the professor's teaching. In another case, conduct involving students or the classroom may create a legitimate institutional concern. A public figure may make an offensive statement that has nothing to do with their professional work, while another person's public conduct may directly undermine the responsibilities associated with their position.

The point is not that consequences are never justified. The point is that connection matters.

If we believe that people should generally be left alone, then we should be reluctant to assume that every disagreement gives us a legitimate claim over every part of another person's life. A person does not surrender every aspect of their private existence simply because they have entered public life. Nor does becoming an employee, an artist, a professor, a business owner, or a public figure automatically mean that every opinion they express becomes subject to every possible consequence.

At the same time, the principle cannot be turned into an absolute shield against consequences. People make choices, and choices can affect the relationships they have with other people and institutions. A company is not necessarily required to ignore conduct that legitimately affects its business. A university is not necessarily required to ignore conduct that violates its rules. A consumer is not required to continue supporting an artist whose behavior they find objectionable. An employer, within the limits established by law and its own legitimate policies, may have reasons for making decisions about an employee.

This is where the distinction between consequence and retaliation becomes important.

A consequence can arise naturally from the choices people make. If I say something publicly and people decide they no longer want to listen to me, I have experienced a consequence of losing their interest. If customers stop buying a product because they disagree with a company's conduct, the company experiences an economic consequence. If an organization decides that a person's behavior no longer fits its mission, the organization may decide not to continue the relationship.

Retaliation raises a different question. If the purpose is not simply to make a choice about one's own participation but to punish someone for exercising a right, or to make an example of someone so that others will be afraid to express similar views, the nature of the action becomes more complicated. The same outward result—a person losing a job, a contract, an audience, or an opportunity—can arise from very different circumstances. We cannot understand the meaning of the event simply by looking at the result.

That is why the question should not merely be, “Was this person canceled?”

We should ask: What happened? Why did it happen? Who made the decision? What authority did they have? What relationship existed between the people involved? What rule, if any, was applied? And was the consequence connected to the conduct in question?

Those questions force us to examine the boundary instead of assuming that the answer is obvious.

There is also a temptation to expand the boundary in the opposite direction. Sometimes we see a person suffer a consequence we consider unfair and immediately conclude that nobody should ever be permitted to impose such a consequence. But that can erase the legitimate freedom of other people to make their own choices. If an audience no longer wants to listen to an artist, the artist does not automatically possess a right to that audience. If consumers no longer want to purchase a product, the company does not automatically possess a right to their money. If a private organization decides not to invite a speaker, that decision may be controversial, but controversy alone does not establish that the speaker was legally entitled to the invitation.

Again, the Right to Leave People Alone works in both directions.

It protects the person who wants to be left alone from unnecessary interference, but it also protects the person who wants to walk away. The consumer has a right to say, “I will not buy this.” The audience member has a right to say, “I will not watch this.” The employee may have a right to leave the workplace. The organization may have a right, subject to applicable law, to decide whom it will employ or associate with.

The difficult part is determining when those choices remain choices about our own participation and when they become attempts to exercise authority over someone else's life.

That is the boundary we keep encountering.

And because political disagreement makes people emotional, we are constantly tempted to move that boundary depending on who is involved. We may defend a boycott when it targets a company we dislike and condemn it when it targets a company we support. We may believe a private institution should have complete freedom to establish standards until those standards affect someone whose

politics we agree with. We may insist that people should face consequences for speech we consider offensive while objecting when the same principle is applied to speech we consider valuable.

That is precisely why the Consistency Test matters.

The question is not whether we can imagine a consequence we dislike. We can. The question is whether the principle we use to justify that consequence would still make sense if the political identities were reversed.

A free society cannot eliminate consequences. Nor should it try to eliminate every form of political pressure. What it can do is force us to distinguish between the different kinds of power people exercise over one another.

Some consequences are simply the result of people making their own choices. Some are the legitimate exercise of institutional authority. Some may be unjustified uses of private power. Some may involve coercion.

And some involve government power, which raises an entirely different set of constitutional questions. The mistake is treating all of them as though they were the same thing simply because the person on the receiving end feels that they have been “canceled.”

The word describes the experience. It does not necessarily explain the mechanism. And once again, the mechanism matters.

The Difference Between “I Won't” and “You Can't”

There may be no more useful distinction in this entire article than the difference between these two ideas: “I won't” and “You can't.” Saying, “I won't watch your show,” is a personal choice. Saying, “You can't have a show,” is an attempt to control someone else's opportunity. Saying, “I won't buy your product,” is a consumer decision, while saying, “You can't sell your product,” is something different. Refusing to associate with someone is one person's boundary; telling that person they are not allowed to associate with anyone else is an attempt to impose a boundary on somebody else.

The distinction sounds simple because, at first, it is. We make decisions about our own participation every day. We decide what to watch, what to read, where to shop, whom to follow, which organizations to join, which causes to support, and which people we want to spend time with. Nobody else is automatically entitled to our participation simply because they want it. The freedom to say “I won't” is therefore an important part of the freedom we have been discussing throughout this article.

But “I won't” can become confused with “you shouldn't.” And “you shouldn't” can eventually become “you can't.”

Those are three very different statements.

If I decide that I will no longer watch a particular television program because I object to something its host said, I have made a decision about my own behavior. If I tell my friends why I made that decision and encourage them to do the same, I am trying to persuade other people to make a similar choice. If

enough people agree with me, the program may lose viewers, advertisers, revenue, or eventually its existence.

That can be a significant consequence.

But the fact that my choice has consequences for someone else does not mean I have taken away their freedom. I exercised my own choice, and other people exercised theirs.

This is an important point because freedom does not mean freedom from consequences. If I open a restaurant, I am free to sell food, but customers are free to decide they do not like it. If I publish a book, I am free to express my ideas within the law, but readers are free not to buy it. If I make a political argument, I am free to make the argument within the protections afforded by law, but other people are free to criticize me. If I support a controversial cause, other people are free to decide that they do not want to associate with me because of it.

A free society contains all of those choices at the same time.

That is why the existence of a negative consequence does not, by itself, establish that someone has been unjustly “canceled.” Sometimes what looks like cancellation is simply the marketplace of individual choice operating as it always has. A consumer decides not to buy. A viewer decides not to watch. A reader decides not to subscribe. A member decides not to participate. A donor decides not to contribute.

The person on the receiving end may dislike those decisions intensely. They are still decisions other people are entitled to make. The situation changes when we move from controlling our own participation to controlling someone else's ability to participate. That is the crucial difference between “I won't” and “you can't.” “I won't buy your product” means I am withholding my own money.

“You can't sell your product” means I am claiming authority over whether you may conduct your business. “I won't attend your event” means I am choosing not to participate. “You can't hold your event” means I am attempting to determine whether you are permitted to hold it.

“I won't listen to your speech” means I am declining to listen. “You can't give that speech” means I am attempting to determine whether you are allowed to speak. The words are similar. The exercise of power is not.

That distinction does not mean that the second statement is automatically unlawful or that every effort to prevent an action is illegitimate. There are circumstances in which government can lawfully regulate conduct, institutions can establish rules, and people can seek legal remedies when their rights are violated. The point is that the justification has to come from somewhere. We cannot simply move from “I don't want this” to “therefore nobody should be allowed to have it.”

That leap is precisely what the Right to Leave People Alone is designed to make us question.

Consider a boycott. A boycott can be extremely powerful. If enough people refuse to buy a company's products, the company may lose substantial revenue. It may change its policies. It may fire executives. It may close stores. It may eventually fail. None of those outcomes automatically means the boycotters violated the company's rights. They made choices about where their money would go and attempted to persuade others to do the same.

Historically, that form of pressure has been an important part of American political life. Revolutionary Americans used nonimportation agreements to pressure British merchants. Abolitionists encouraged consumers to purchase goods produced without slave labor. Civil Rights activists used boycotts to pressure businesses and institutions. Labor movements have used economic pressure to influence employers. Modern Americans continue to use their purchasing decisions as a form of political expression.

The mechanism is important. They were not necessarily saying, “You are forbidden from doing this.” They were saying, “We will not participate unless you change.” That is pressure, but pressure is not automatically coercion.

A person can attempt to persuade another person without controlling that person's decision. A group can organize without possessing governmental authority. Consumers can act collectively without becoming the state. A company can lose customers without those customers becoming a government regulator.

This is why the sheer size of a response cannot be the only measure we use. Ten people refusing to buy something and ten million people refusing to buy something are obviously very different in their economic consequences. But the underlying mechanism may still be voluntary choice. The ten million people have more influence because there are ten million of them, not necessarily because any one of them possesses the legal authority to force the company to comply.

At the same time, we should not pretend that private pressure is therefore insignificant.

It can be enormous.

A coordinated campaign can affect someone's employment, reputation, livelihood, business relationships, or ability to find another job. A social-media controversy can spread information—accurate or inaccurate—to millions of people within hours. An employer may respond to public pressure. Advertisers may withdraw. Customers may leave. Professional organizations may reconsider relationships.

Those consequences deserve examination. But the examination should begin with who exercised the power and how. Was the person criticized? Was the person boycotted? Did customers voluntarily stop purchasing? Did an employer independently make a decision? Did an institution apply an established rule? Were threats involved? Was false information deliberately spread? Was someone physically prevented from participating? Was government authority used?

These questions matter because two events can produce the same result while involving completely different forms of power.

Someone can lose a job because an employer legitimately concludes that the person violated workplace rules. Someone else can lose a job because an employer capitulates to threats. Someone can lose an audience because consumers no longer want to support them. Someone else can be prevented from speaking because government officials use their authority to suppress the speech.

From the outside, all four people might say, “I was canceled.” The phrase does not tell us what actually happened.

That is why the language of “I won't” and “you can't” is so useful. It gives us a way to move beyond the emotional description of the outcome and examine the mechanism that produced it.

There is another reason this distinction matters: the same person can move from one category to another without necessarily realizing it.

I can begin by saying, “I won't watch this person.” Then I can say, “You shouldn't watch this person.” Then I can say, “Nobody should support this person.” And eventually I might reach, “This person should not be allowed to have a platform.”

Each step represents an expansion of the boundary.

The first statement concerns my own behavior. The second attempts to influence someone else's behavior. The third seeks broader social pressure. The fourth begins to raise a question about who should possess the authority to determine whether another person may participate at all.

There may be legitimate reasons to move from one step to another. There may be conduct serious enough to justify institutional action or legal intervention. But the movement should never happen automatically simply because we are angry.

That is where the Consistency Test becomes useful again.

Would we make the same distinction if the person being targeted held the opposite political position? Would we defend the consumer boycott if the people organizing it supported a cause we disliked? Would we defend the private institution's right to establish its own rules if those rules produced an outcome we found offensive? Would we still believe that government should stay out of the dispute if government officials were being asked to suppress speech we personally found dangerous?

If our answer changes entirely depending on whose politics are involved, then the principle has probably become an instrument for defending our preferred outcome.

The harder standard is to ask whether the same boundary should apply when we are the ones on the other side of it.

That does not require pretending that every dispute is morally equivalent. It does not require abandoning judgment. It does not mean that every private decision is wise or that every boycott is justified. It means that before we claim authority over someone else's choices, we should be able to explain what gives us that authority.

There is a profound difference between saying:

“I will not participate.”

and saying:

“You may not participate.”

The first is an exercise of personal freedom. The second is a claim of power. Sometimes that claim of power may be justified. But it should never be invisible simply because we agree with the reason behind it.

That is the larger lesson of the distinction. The question is not whether we should ever pressure anyone. Americans have been pressuring one another politically for centuries, and much of that pressure has been essential to political change. The question is whether we understand the difference between using our freedom to influence another person's choices and claiming the authority to remove those choices altogether.

Once again, the mechanism matters.

And that leads directly into the next question: what happens when millions of individual choices become powerful enough to produce consequences that look, from the outside, almost indistinguishable from coercion?

The Marketplace of Choice

This is one reason the marketplace is so central to the American tradition of protest. Americans have repeatedly discovered that they possess another form of political power: the ability to decide where their money goes. Revolutionary nonimportation agreements, abolitionist free-produce campaigns, Civil Rights boycotts, labor boycotts, and modern consumer campaigns all demonstrate the same basic mechanism. Instead of asking the government to force someone to change, citizens sometimes try to make the consequences of continuing a particular practice economically significant. The marketplace can therefore become a political arena, not because every purchase is a political act, but because people sometimes use their economic choices deliberately to express political convictions.

The important thing about this form of pressure is that it begins with something the individual already controls: their own participation. I can decide that I will not purchase a particular product. I can decide that I will not attend a particular business. I can decide that I will not subscribe to a publication, donate to an organization, or financially support a political cause. I can then tell other people why I made that decision and encourage them to consider doing the same. Other people remain free to agree with me, ignore me, or decide that they will continue spending their money exactly as they did before.

That distinction matters because economic power is still power, even when it is voluntary.

A large enough group of consumers can affect a company's revenue, reputation, hiring decisions, advertising relationships, or business strategy. A successful boycott can force an institution to reconsider a policy that it previously had no intention of changing. From the perspective of the institution being targeted, the consequences may be substantial and very real. But the fact that a voluntary decision produces a powerful consequence does not, by itself, transform that decision into coercion.

That is one of the reasons boycotts have occupied such an important place in American political history. The colonists who participated in nonimportation agreements were not merely expressing an opinion about British policy; they were attempting to make continued participation in the existing economic system politically costly. Abolitionists used consumer choices to challenge the economics of slavery. Civil Rights activists used boycotts to challenge businesses and institutions that participated in segregation. Labor movements have used economic pressure to demand changes from employers. In

each case, the basic idea was that people could exercise power not only through government but through their own collective decisions.

There is nothing inherently undemocratic about that. In many circumstances, it is democracy operating outside the ballot box.

That phrase deserves some explanation, however, because a boycott is not literally an election. Consumers do not cast ballots that legally bind a company in the same way voters elect a government. A boycott works through voluntary association and economic consequences rather than through the exercise of sovereign governmental authority. Its power comes from the number of people willing to participate and from the importance of what they are willing to give up in order to make their point.

That can make boycotts both powerful and unpredictable. A campaign may begin with a small group of activists and eventually attract thousands or millions of participants. It may fail completely because most people decide that the issue is not important enough to change their behavior. It may succeed in changing a company's policy. It may instead damage a business without producing the change its organizers wanted. Or it may become so politically charged that the original dispute becomes almost secondary to the fight over the boycott itself.

None of those outcomes changes the underlying principle: people are generally entitled to decide how they spend their own money, and they are generally entitled to encourage other people to make their own choices.

But this is where the question becomes more difficult.

When does persuasion become coercion?

A boycott asks someone to change because continuing a behavior may cost them customers. A threat says that something worse will happen if they do not comply. Those are not necessarily the same thing. The distinction becomes particularly important when intimidation, violence, stalking, threats against employees or families, or other unlawful conduct enters the picture.

Consider two statements.

“I will not buy your product unless you change this policy.”

“Change this policy or I will make sure you and your employees suffer.”

Both statements are attempts to produce a change. Both may arise from the same political disagreement. But they do not exercise the same kind of power. The first identifies a consequence that the speaker controls: the speaker's own decision not to participate. The second threatens to impose an additional harm on the other person if they refuse to comply.

The difference is not merely rhetorical.

If I tell a company that I will stop buying its products, I am exercising my own economic freedom. If I persuade a hundred friends to do the same, I am using persuasion to encourage other people to exercise theirs. If a hundred thousand people independently make the same decision, the economic consequences may become enormous, but the mechanism remains voluntary participation.

Now imagine something different. Suppose people threaten employees because the company will not change its policy. Suppose protesters physically prevent customers from entering the business. Suppose someone threatens violence against a store owner unless the owner complies with the campaign's demands. At that point, the question is no longer simply whether people are exercising economic pressure. The method has changed, and with it the nature of the power being exercised.

This is why the size of a campaign cannot be the only measure we use.

A million people deciding not to buy something can have more economic impact than ten people making threats, but economic impact and coercion are not the same concept. A successful boycott may cause a company to lose millions of dollars while remaining entirely dependent on voluntary choices. Conversely, a small group using threats can exercise coercive power even if the financial consequences are relatively minor. The number of people involved tells us something about the scale of the pressure; it does not tell us by itself what kind of pressure it is.

The same principle applies to social pressure.

If I tell other people, “I think this person's behavior is unacceptable, and I don't think you should support them,” I am attempting to persuade them. They may agree. They may disagree. If enough people agree, the person may lose an audience, customers, donors, or professional opportunities. Those consequences may be painful, and they may even be unfair. But we still have to examine how they occurred rather than assuming that the existence of a consequence proves that coercion took place.

That is especially important in a society where people possess different forms of private power. Consumers have economic power. Employers have employment power. Universities have institutional power. Publishers have editorial power. Media organizations have platform power. Professional organizations have membership power. Online communities have social and reputational power. None of these forms of power is identical to government authority, and none should be automatically treated as though it were.

At the same time, recognizing that private power is different from government power does not require us to pretend that private power is insignificant. Someone can lose their livelihood without the government having censored them. A business can lose customers without the government having ordered those customers to leave. An organization can lose donors without the government having prohibited anyone from supporting it. The consequences can still be serious enough to deserve public discussion.

The useful question is therefore not simply, “Was someone canceled?”

It is: Who acted, what did they do, what authority did they possess, and what freedom remained to the person on the receiving end?

That brings us directly back to the principle we have been developing throughout this article. You have the right to decide where your money goes. You have the right to persuade others about where their money should go. Other people have the right to reject your argument. And the people or institutions being pressured still possess whatever rights and lawful choices the system gives them.

The Consistency Test applies here just as strongly as it does anywhere else. If we defend boycotts when they target a company whose politics we oppose, we have to recognize that the same economic mechanism can be used against a company whose politics we support. If we believe consumers should be free to withdraw their money over one political issue, we have to recognize that consumers may withdraw their money over an issue we consider foolish, offensive, or deeply misguided. If our principle is genuinely about economic freedom, it cannot depend entirely upon whether we approve of the reason someone is exercising that freedom.

That does not mean every boycott is justified, every demand is reasonable, or every campaign is based on accurate information. People can make bad arguments. They can repeat false accusations. They can behave hypocritically. They can organize campaigns that are disproportionate to the conduct they are responding to. A free society does not eliminate those possibilities. It gives people the freedom to respond to them as well.

And that is ultimately what makes the marketplace of choice different from government coercion.

The consumer's power begins with the ability to say:

“I will not participate.”

The consumer can then ask others to make the same choice.

What the consumer does not automatically possess is the authority to decide that nobody else may participate.

That distinction takes us directly into the next question: pressure is not automatically coercion.

Pressure Is Not Automatically Coercion

We have to be careful with this distinction because political movements have always used pressure. The abolitionists pressured consumers, Civil Rights activists pressured businesses, labor organizers pressured employers, suffragists pressured politicians, and Vietnam protesters pressured universities, corporations, and government officials. Modern political movements pressure advertisers, media companies, universities, entertainers, and elected officials. Pressure is not an unusual departure from American political life. Pressure is part of political participation. Sources: National Archives: 19th Amendment | NPS: Montgomery Bus Boycott

In fact, it is difficult to imagine democratic politics without it. Elections themselves are a form of pressure: candidates ask voters to reject one set of policies and support another. Advocacy groups pressure legislators by presenting arguments, organizing constituents, publishing research, contacting representatives, and mobilizing supporters. Protesters pressure institutions by making disagreement visible. Consumers pressure businesses by deciding where to spend their money. Workers can pressure employers through organizing and lawful collective action. Citizens can pressure one another through persuasion, criticism, public argument, and association.

The existence of pressure, therefore, does not tell us whether something is legitimate or illegitimate. We have to look at how the pressure is being applied, what is being demanded, who is applying it, and what happens if the target refuses to comply.

That last question is particularly important.

If I tell a company, “I will stop buying your product unless you change this policy,” I have made a demand backed by my own economic choice. The company may decide that losing my business is insignificant. It may decide that the policy is more important than my business. It may decide that I have a point and change the policy. If I persuade thousands of other consumers to make the same choice, the pressure becomes much greater, but the basic mechanism remains the same: people are deciding for themselves whether they will participate.

Now change the situation.

If I tell the company, “Change this policy or I will physically harm your employees,” I have crossed into something entirely different. The demand may be identical—change the policy—but the means of obtaining compliance are no longer based on my voluntary participation. I am threatening to impose harm on someone else if they refuse. The political objective may be one I consider noble, but the mechanism has changed the nature of the act.

This distinction is important because people often judge political pressure primarily by the cause behind it. If we agree with the objective, we are more likely to describe the pressure as activism. If we oppose the objective, we are more likely to describe the same pressure as intimidation or coercion. That is precisely where the Consistency Test becomes useful. A principle that depends entirely on which side is applying the pressure is not much of a principle at all.

Imagine two groups organizing boycotts against two different companies. One group supports a cause you strongly believe in. The other group supports a cause you consider deeply misguided. Both groups ask consumers to stop purchasing from their respective companies. If your definition of a legitimate boycott changes depending on which political cause you prefer, then you are not really evaluating the mechanism. You are evaluating the politics.

That does not mean the political objective is irrelevant. Of course it matters whether a campaign is responding to something real, whether its claims are accurate, whether its demands are proportionate, and whether the conduct being challenged is itself harmful. A political campaign can be based on false information or wildly exaggerated accusations. It can unfairly target an individual who had little connection to the conduct at issue. It can demand consequences that have little relationship to the original dispute. Those are legitimate questions.

But they are different questions from whether the pressure itself is coercive.

A person can make a terrible argument without threatening anyone. A group can organize around a foolish cause without using violence. Consumers can participate in an unfair boycott without physically forcing a business to comply. Conversely, a person can use coercion in support of a cause that many people consider morally justified.

The cause does not automatically determine the mechanism.

History gives us plenty of examples of political movements applying serious pressure without that pressure necessarily taking the form of government coercion or physical force. The American Revolution involved economic pressure against British goods. Abolitionists encouraged consumers to reject products associated with slavery. Civil Rights activists organized boycotts against businesses that participated in segregation. Labor movements have used strikes, boycotts, organizing, and public campaigns to pressure employers. Suffragists used demonstrations, organizing, lobbying, and public advocacy to pressure political institutions.

These movements did not merely ask politely.

They attempted to change the behavior of people and institutions by making continued behavior more difficult, more expensive, more politically costly, or more publicly visible. That is part of how social movements operate. If political participation were limited to expressing an opinion and then accepting whatever happens, many of the historical movements we now regard as important would have possessed far less ability to challenge established institutions.

So the question cannot simply be whether someone was pressured.

The better question is what kind of pressure was applied?

There is a meaningful difference between persuasion, pressure, punishment, coercion, and force. They can overlap, and real situations do not always fit neatly into one category, but the distinctions still matter. Persuasion attempts to change someone's mind. Pressure attempts to make a particular choice more attractive or another choice more costly. Punishment involves imposing a consequence for conduct, usually through some recognized authority or established rule. Coercion involves using threats or other means to deprive someone of meaningful freedom of choice. Force involves physical compulsion or violence.

Those categories can become complicated very quickly.

A customer who says, “I will not shop here anymore,” is making a personal choice. A group that says, “We encourage everyone in our community not to shop here,” is applying collective pressure. An employer that says, “You violated our workplace rules, and your employment is terminated,” is exercising institutional authority, subject to applicable law and the terms governing the employment relationship. A person who says, “Change your policy or I will attack you,” is making a threat. These actions can all arise from the same political disagreement, but they do not represent the same exercise of power.

This is why the word “cancel” can be so limiting.

The word describes the outcome from the perspective of the person experiencing the consequences. It does not necessarily tell us what produced those consequences. A person may feel canceled because customers stopped buying their product. Another person may feel canceled because an employer terminated their employment. Someone else may feel canceled because a private platform removed their account. Another may describe themselves as canceled because government officials restricted their access to a government-controlled forum or facility.

The experiences may feel similar to the people involved.

The mechanisms are not.

That distinction becomes particularly important when we move from voluntary economic choices to institutional decisions. A company may decide that an employee's conduct violates its policies. A university may decide that an event does not meet its established standards. A publisher may decide not to publish a particular author. A media organization may decide to cancel a program. Those institutions are exercising their own forms of authority, and their decisions can certainly be criticized. But criticism of a private decision is different from automatically labeling that decision government censorship.

At the same time, we should not make the opposite mistake and assume that private pressure is therefore harmless. A private employer can have enormous influence over someone's livelihood. A large corporation can have significant economic power. A major university can affect someone's education or career. A media organization can affect someone's ability to reach an audience. A social platform can affect someone's ability to communicate with millions of people.

Private power is still power.

That is why the question of coercion cannot be reduced to a simple government-versus-private distinction either. Government authority carries special constitutional significance because government possesses powers that private citizens generally do not. But the fact that private actors lack sovereign authority does not mean every exercise of private power deserves automatic approval. We still have to ask whether the decision is connected to a legitimate interest, whether the rules were applied consistently, whether the information was accurate, whether the response was proportionate, and whether unlawful conduct was involved.

There is another distinction worth preserving: pressure can be intense without being coercive.

A boycott that causes a company to lose millions of dollars can be extremely powerful. A sustained public campaign can seriously damage a person's reputation. A widespread refusal to work with an organization can threaten its survival. These consequences can be devastating to the people or institutions experiencing them. But severity of consequence and coercion are not identical concepts. The fact that an action hurts does not tell us by itself whether someone was unlawfully or forcibly compelled.

The reverse is also true.

A threat does not become legitimate simply because it is unlikely to be carried out. Physical intimidation does not become acceptable because only a small number of people are involved. Stalking does not become ordinary political pressure because the person doing it believes strongly in the cause. Violence does not become democratic participation simply because the person using it claims to be defending democracy.

Again, the mechanism matters.

This is ultimately what the marketplace of choice was meant to establish. Citizens possess real power outside government. They can spend their money or withhold it. They can persuade other people. They can organize. They can protest. They can boycott. They can criticize institutions and ask those institutions to change. Those forms of pressure are not inherently threats to liberty. In many

circumstances, they are among the ways a free society allows people without formal political authority to exercise influence.

But the existence of that freedom carries a responsibility.

If we want the freedom to pressure institutions we oppose, we have to recognize that people who oppose our causes possess the same freedom. If we defend boycotts when they hurt a company whose politics we dislike, we have to accept that a boycott can also hurt a company whose politics we support. If we believe activists should be allowed to organize public pressure campaigns, we have to recognize that opposing activists may organize their own campaigns. And if we believe coercion crosses a line, that line has to remain a line even when the person crossing it is fighting for something we believe in.

That is the harder version of the Consistency Test.

It asks us to evaluate the mechanism before we celebrate or condemn the outcome.

The question is not simply, “Did this person get pressured?”

The question is: “How were they pressured, what were they being asked to do, and what happened when they refused?”

Once we ask those questions, the word “cancel” becomes less useful as a conclusion and more useful as a starting point. It tells us that someone experienced a loss of support, opportunity, access, reputation, employment, or participation. It does not tell us whether that consequence resulted from ordinary disagreement, voluntary choice, collective pressure, institutional authority, coercion, or government action.

And that brings us to the next question: What are you actually asking for?

What Are You Actually Asking For?

This is where the article's central question becomes useful again. Suppose you are angry about something a public figure said. What do you actually want? Do you want to answer the argument, expose what you believe is false, tell other people what the person said, encourage consumers to stop supporting the person, ask the person's employer to reconsider its relationship with them, demand that a private platform remove the person, ask the government to prohibit the speech, or demand that the person be punished for expressing it?

Those are very different requests, even when they begin with exactly the same disagreement. The person making the complaint may sincerely believe that every step on that list is justified. But moving from one step to another means moving from one kind of power to another, and sometimes from exercising your own freedom to asking someone else to exercise authority over another person. That is why the first question should not simply be, “Was I offended?” or even, “Was what this person said wrong?” The more useful question is: What am I actually asking to happen?

Start with the simplest possibility: you want to be heard.

A person says something you believe is offensive, dishonest, discriminatory, hypocritical, or dangerous, and you want other people to know what was said. You share the statement. You provide context. You explain why you object. You present evidence. You write an article, make a video, publish a response, organize a demonstration, or speak at a public meeting. The person you are criticizing may strongly dislike what you are doing, but public argument is part of a free society.

Much of American political history works this way. Abolitionists published arguments intended to make slavery impossible to ignore. Civil Rights activists publicized discriminatory treatment that many Americans had previously been able to ignore. Investigative journalists have exposed government misconduct, corporate wrongdoing, and institutional failures. Protest movements have deliberately brought uncomfortable subjects into public view because they believed existing institutions were refusing to address them.

The important question at this stage is not whether the criticism is comfortable.

It is whether the criticism is grounded in something that can actually be examined.

That distinction matters because public criticism can be both powerful and responsible. You can present evidence that a politician made a particular statement. You can show what a corporation did. You can explain why you believe a university policy is unfair. You can challenge someone's argument and invite other people to examine the same evidence. The person being criticized remains free to respond, dispute your interpretation, provide additional information, or criticize you in return.

That is argument. The next possibility is different: you want people to walk away.

Perhaps you do not want anyone to watch the person's program, purchase their products, attend their performances, donate to their organization, or vote for their candidate. Perhaps you want advertisers to reconsider where they spend their money. Perhaps you are organizing a boycott because you believe the person or institution has violated a principle important enough to justify withdrawing your own support and encouraging others to do the same.

That is a familiar form of American political action. The Revolutionaries used economic pressure against British goods. Abolitionists developed free-produce campaigns. Civil Rights activists used boycotts to challenge segregation. Labor movements have repeatedly used consumer pressure and boycotts as organizing tools. The underlying principle is straightforward: you control your own participation and, within the law, you can encourage other people to make their own choices as well.

That does not guarantee that the target will consider the campaign fair. It does not guarantee that the campaign will succeed. It does not even guarantee that the underlying argument is correct. It simply recognizes that voluntary economic and social choices are themselves forms of political power.

Then we reach another level: you want an institution to act.

Perhaps you are not asking ordinary people to walk away. You are asking a private institution to make a decision. You want an employer to discipline an employee, a university to cancel an event, a television network to end a program, a publisher to drop an author, or a professional organization to sever a relationship.

Sometimes that request concerns a legitimate institutional interest. Organizations have rules. Employees have responsibilities. Universities and professional organizations establish standards. Publishers and media companies make editorial decisions. Institutions have to determine whom they will employ, invite, publish, sponsor, or associate with, subject to applicable law and whatever contractual or other obligations govern the situation.

But the existence of a legitimate institutional decision does not automatically make every demand for institutional punishment legitimate.

An institution can be pressured into making a decision based on inaccurate information. An accusation can be exaggerated. A social-media campaign can turn a complicated incident into a simplified narrative. A political movement can decide that the real objective is not accountability for particular conduct but making an example of a particular person. The fact that an institution has the authority to make a decision does not mean that every reason offered for exercising that authority is sound.

That brings us to an important distinction: asking an institution to exercise its own authority is not the same thing as personally possessing that authority.

If I ask a newspaper not to publish an article, I have made a request. The newspaper still decides whether to publish it. If I ask an employer to discipline an employee, the employer still has to decide whether the conduct actually violates its rules or applicable law. If I ask a university to cancel an event, university officials must decide whether the request is consistent with the institution's policies and responsibilities.

The person making the demand has influence. The institution makes the decision. That distinction becomes increasingly important as we move toward government. Before we get there, however, there is another possibility: you want silence.

There is a difference between saying, “I don't want to hear this,” and saying, “Nobody should be allowed to hear this.” The first is an exercise of personal choice. The second is an attempt to control other people's access to information or expression.

Those two statements can sound similar because they may arise from the same emotional reaction. A person may find a speaker so offensive that they personally leave the room. Another person may organize a peaceful protest asking the organization hosting the speaker not to invite them again. A third person may demand that the government prohibit the speech entirely.

The underlying objection may be identical. The authority being requested is not.

That is where the distinction becomes particularly important. A person who walks away is exercising control over their own participation. A person who persuades others to walk away is attempting to influence their choices. A private institution deciding whether to host the speaker is exercising its own institutional authority. But asking the government to prohibit protected political expression raises an entirely different constitutional question because government possesses coercive powers that private citizens and organizations generally do not.

The farther we move along this spectrum, the more carefully we should examine what is being requested.

This does not mean that the government can never restrict conduct or expression. Constitutional rights have boundaries, and the legal system recognizes circumstances in which speech and conduct can be regulated. But the burden of justification is fundamentally different when the requested action involves government authority. The question is no longer merely whether the speaker is offensive or whether people would prefer not to hear them. It becomes a question of what legal authority the government possesses and whether using that authority is consistent with constitutional protections.

That is why the phrase “I want them canceled” tells us so little by itself.

What does “canceled” mean?

Does it mean you want to criticize them? Do you want people to stop buying their work? Do you want their employer to investigate something they did? Do you want a private organization to end its relationship with them? Do you want a platform to remove their account? Do you want them denied access to a particular private forum? Do you want the government to prevent them from speaking? Do you want them prosecuted for conduct that may actually violate a law?

Those are not interchangeable demands.

They involve different decision-makers, different kinds of authority, different potential consequences, and different questions about individual rights.

This is also why we should resist the temptation to treat every negative consequence as though it were imposed by a single, coordinated force called “society.” Society is not one person. It is made up of millions of individuals and thousands of institutions, each possessing different amounts and kinds of power. Sometimes an individual chooses to stop supporting someone. Sometimes many individuals independently make the same choice. Sometimes activists organize those individuals into a campaign. Sometimes an employer makes an institutional decision. Sometimes a government agency acts.

Those circumstances can produce similar outcomes while operating through completely different mechanisms.

Imagine that a musician makes a political statement. One listener stops buying the musician's music. Another listener writes an article criticizing the statement. A group organizes a boycott. An advertiser decides it no longer wants to sponsor the musician's program. The musician's employer reviews the situation and decides whether workplace rules were violated. Finally, imagine that government officials attempt to prohibit the musician from expressing the political opinion.

All of those actions could arise from the same original statement.

They are still not the same action.

This is where the Consistency Test becomes especially useful. If we believe people should be free to criticize political speech we dislike, that principle should not disappear when the speaker is expressing an idea we support. If we believe consumers should be free to withdraw their money, that freedom cannot depend entirely on whether we approve of the reason for the boycott. If we believe private institutions should have authority to establish legitimate standards, we should recognize that authority even when the institution reaches an outcome we dislike. And if we believe government should not

punish protected political expression, we should be cautious about creating exceptions simply because the speaker's views make us angry.

The test is not whether we approve of the person.

The test is whether we believe in the principle when the circumstances are reversed.

There is another reason this question matters. Once we identify what we are actually asking for, we can also ask whether the requested consequence is connected to the conduct that produced the controversy.

Suppose an employee makes a statement unrelated to their job. An employer may reasonably have questions about whether the statement violated a workplace rule, affected the employee's ability to perform their responsibilities, or created some other legitimate employment issue. But if the demand is simply, “We dislike this person's political opinion, therefore they should lose every opportunity in their professional life,” the connection becomes much harder to establish.

Likewise, if a company engages in conduct directly related to its business practices, consumers may reasonably decide that the conduct is relevant to whether they want to continue purchasing from that company. But if someone demands that a company be destroyed economically because an employee's distant relative expressed an unrelated political opinion, the connection is much less obvious.

The point is not that there is a universal formula for deciding where the line falls.

The point is that the connection should be examined.

What happened? Who did it? What rule, responsibility, or principle does it implicate? Who is being asked to act? What authority do they possess? What consequence is being demanded? And how closely is that consequence connected to the conduct that produced the dispute?

Those questions move us away from the emotionally satisfying simplicity of saying someone should be “canceled” and toward the much harder work of determining what we actually believe should happen.

That is important because the power to influence another person is not the same as the power to control another person.

You can criticize. You can persuade. You can organize. You can boycott. You can ask an institution to act. But each step raises a different question about whose authority is being exercised and whose freedom is being affected.

And once government enters the picture, the question changes again. That is where the distinction between private pressure and government power becomes impossible to ignore.

The Government Question Returns

Suppose a politician says something you find deeply offensive. You can criticize the politician, campaign against the politician, encourage other voters not to support the politician, organize demonstrations, publish arguments explaining why you believe the politician is wrong, and, depending on the circumstances and applicable law, organize boycotts or encourage others to withdraw support. You can make the politician's words part of the public debate. You can try to persuade other citizens

that those words reveal something important about the politician's character, judgment, priorities, or policies. You can even argue that the politician should face political consequences at the ballot box.

All of those responses involve citizens exercising their own political power. But if your demand is that the government punish the politician for protected political expression, the constitutional analysis changes dramatically. You are no longer asking fellow citizens to make a choice. You are asking the state to use its authority against another citizen or public official because of what that person has said.

That distinction matters even when the underlying objection is completely sincere.

The First Amendment exists in large part because political disagreement cannot safely be left entirely to the government to police. Political speech is not merely another category of expression in a democracy. It is part of the process through which citizens criticize government, challenge public officials, organize movements, advocate for laws, and attempt to persuade one another about the direction of the country. If the government gets to decide which political ideas are acceptable, then the people in power become the ultimate judges of political legitimacy.

That creates a problem that goes beyond any individual controversy.

Imagine a government controlled by people you agree with. They decide that certain political arguments are dangerous and should be restricted. Perhaps you believe they are correct. Perhaps you believe the restrictions are necessary to protect the country. Now imagine the same authority after the next election, when people you strongly disagree with control it.

The power has not changed. Only the people holding it have changed.

That is why constitutional principles are supposed to survive political turnover. The purpose of a constitutional limitation is not simply to protect the people we currently agree with. It is to establish boundaries on government power that remain in place when political circumstances change.

This is one of the reasons the government question has to remain separate from the private-power question we have been examining. A citizen can decide not to listen to a politician. A political organization can campaign against that politician. A newspaper can criticize the politician. A private company can decide whether it wants to advertise with or employ someone, subject to applicable law. Citizens can organize a boycott or encourage other people not to support the politician.

Government occupies a different position.

The state has powers that individual citizens generally do not possess. It can enforce criminal laws, impose legally authorized penalties, conduct investigations, regulate conduct, collect taxes, issue licenses, and exercise other forms of governmental authority. When that authority is brought to bear against political expression, the question is no longer simply whether the response is popular or whether the speaker deserves criticism.

We have to ask what the government is actually doing.

Is it responding to conduct that is independently unlawful? Is it regulating something other than the political viewpoint being expressed? Is it enforcing a generally applicable law? Or is the government using its authority because officials object to what someone is saying?

Those distinctions matter.

A government cannot make a constitutional problem disappear simply by calling political punishment “accountability.” Nor does calling something censorship automatically establish that an unconstitutional act has occurred. The facts, the legal authority involved, and the nature of the government action matter.

That is precisely why the mechanism matters so much.

If I disagree with a politician's speech, I can answer it. If I believe the politician is lying, I can present evidence. If I believe the politician is unfit to hold office, I can campaign against them. If I believe their policies are harmful, I can organize other citizens to oppose those policies. If enough voters agree with me, the politician can lose an election.

That is political competition. The government punishing someone because officials dislike their protected political expression is something different.

The distinction is not about being polite. It is not about requiring citizens to tolerate ideas they consider offensive. It is not even about pretending that every political argument deserves equal respect.

It is about deciding who gets to exercise the power.

Citizens are supposed to possess enormous freedom to argue with one another. They can be passionate. They can be angry. They can be relentless. They can organize campaigns intended to defeat ideas, movements, candidates, and policies. They can attempt to persuade millions of other people that their opponents are wrong.

What they cannot automatically do is transfer that disagreement to the government and ask the government to impose consequences that the government itself has no constitutional authority to impose.

That is where the government's role becomes especially important.

And it brings us back to a lesson from the Nixon examples earlier in this article. The historical concern was not simply that Richard Nixon disliked his critics. Presidents are allowed to dislike critics. Political leaders have always resented hostile newspapers, opponents, protesters, and investigators.

The deeper concern arose when the machinery and authority of the federal government became part of efforts to investigate, pressure, or retaliate against perceived political opponents. That distinction should remain constant regardless of which political party controls the government.

If government power is restrained only when the other side controls it, then the restraint is not really a principle. It is a temporary political preference.

The Consistency Test therefore becomes especially important here. If we believe government should be prevented from punishing political expression when the speaker is someone we support, we have to consider whether we would defend the same limitation when the speaker is someone we believe is dangerous, offensive, or completely wrong.

That does not mean we have to defend the person's ideas. It means we have to distinguish between defending someone's right to speak and defending what they said. Those are not the same thing.

You can believe a politician's statement is terrible and still believe the government should not be given unlimited authority to punish political speech. You can believe a movement is dangerous and still believe that citizens should be allowed to defeat that movement through argument, organizing, elections, lawful protest, and other forms of political participation.

The harder question is what happens when speech becomes conduct, or when conduct actually violates another person's rights. That is where the analysis becomes more complicated, because government has legitimate responsibilities to enforce laws and protect people from genuine violations.

But that is precisely why we have to identify the actual conduct rather than treating political disagreement itself as the offense.

The government question therefore returns us to the principle at the center of this entire discussion:

What are you actually asking the government to do? If the answer is “help me defeat this argument,” that is a political question. If the answer is “help me persuade other citizens,” that is a political question.

If the answer is “enforce a law that applies because someone committed conduct that the law actually prohibits,” that is a governmental question governed by legal standards.

But if the answer is “use government power to silence or punish this person because I believe their political expression is unacceptable,” then we have reached the boundary that the First Amendment was designed to make especially difficult for government to cross.

And that boundary matters whether the person speaking is someone we admire, someone we despise, or someone we have never heard of.

Because once we give government the authority to decide which political voices are allowed to remain, we have changed the nature of the argument. We are no longer simply asking citizens to choose. We are asking the government to choose for them.

What About Private Institutions?

Now change the situation. A private company employs the person, and the company has its own policies and decides that the person's conduct violates those policies. Or a private media company decides that a program no longer fits its editorial standards. Or a private university determines that an invited speaker does not meet its established rules. Those situations are not automatically constitutional free-speech violations simply because speech is involved. Private institutions have their own rights and responsibilities, and applicable laws can differ depending on the institution and circumstances.

This distinction is important because the First Amendment generally limits government action, not every decision made by private individuals or organizations. A private employer is not the government. A private newspaper is not the government. A private university is not the government. A private

website is not the government. That does not mean those institutions can do literally anything they want, but it does mean that the constitutional question cannot simply be transferred from the public sphere to the private sphere without examining who actually possesses the authority being used.

Consider an employer. If an employee expresses a political opinion outside of work and the employer decides to terminate that employee, people may reasonably debate whether the decision is fair, wise, proportionate, or consistent with the company's stated values. But the fact that the employee's speech is involved does not automatically make the firing government censorship. The employer is exercising its own authority within a private relationship, subject to employment contracts, applicable laws, and whatever other legal protections govern the situation.

The same basic distinction applies to media organizations. A newspaper does not have a constitutional obligation to publish every opinion submitted to it simply because the opinion is protected from government censorship. A television network can make editorial decisions about its programming. A publisher can decide which books it wants to publish. A private organization can establish rules about whom it wants to invite, employ, sponsor, or associate with, within the limits imposed by law.

Those decisions can still be criticized. In fact, they should be.

The fact that an institution has the legal right to make a decision does not automatically mean that the decision was wise. Legality and wisdom are different questions. A decision can be lawful and still be unfair. It can be lawful and still be disproportionate. It can be lawful and still reveal an institutional culture that people have legitimate reasons to challenge. It can also be unpopular without being wrong.

That distinction matters because otherwise we fall into the opposite mistake. If the government is not involved, we might conclude that nothing important has happened. But private power can be enormous.

An employer can affect a person's livelihood. A university can affect someone's education and professional future. A media company can determine whether a person reaches an audience. A publisher can determine whether an author's work reaches the market. A professional organization can affect membership and career opportunities. A major online platform can determine whether someone has access to an audience that may number in the millions.

None of those institutions is the government. That does not make their power imaginary. This is why “private” cannot be treated as the end of the analysis. It is the beginning of a different analysis.

We have to ask what kind of institution is involved, what authority it possesses, what rules govern that authority, what relationship exists between the institution and the person affected, and what consequences follow from the decision. We also have to ask whether the institution is responding to legitimate conduct-related concerns or simply reacting to political pressure.

That last distinction is especially important.

Suppose an employee violates a clearly established workplace rule. The employer investigates the conduct and imposes a consequence consistent with its policies. That is one kind of institutional decision.

Now suppose an employee expresses a political opinion completely unrelated to their job. Thousands of people become angry about the opinion and demand that the employee be fired. The employer then dismisses the employee solely because of the political pressure.

Those situations may produce the same result—a person loses their job—but the reasoning behind the decision is very different.

And that is precisely why the mechanism matters.

The private institution may possess the legal authority to make the decision. The public still has the ability to examine whether the institution is using that authority responsibly. Consumers can respond. Employees can respond. Journalists can investigate. Other organizations can refuse to associate with the institution. Legislators can debate whether existing laws are adequate. Citizens can organize around the issue.

Private power therefore exists inside a larger civic environment.

There is no single government censor sitting above it all, but there are millions of decisions being made by people and institutions that possess different kinds of authority. Those decisions can reinforce one another, produce significant consequences, and sometimes create pressures that are difficult for an individual to resist.

That makes private power worth taking seriously without pretending that it is identical to government power.

The difference matters most when we talk about rights.

A person may strongly prefer to work for a particular company, but that preference does not automatically create a legal right to employment. A person may desperately want a newspaper to publish their article, but that does not automatically create a right to publication. A person may want access to a private platform, but the existence of that desire does not automatically create a constitutional entitlement to that platform.

At the same time, private institutions do not operate in a legal vacuum. Employment discrimination laws exist. Contract law exists. Consumer-protection laws exist. Particular industries and institutions can be subject to specific legal requirements. A private actor may therefore have significant freedom without having unlimited freedom.

The details matter.

That is why the question “Is this censorship?” is often too crude to be useful. We need to know who acted, what authority they possessed, what rule they were applying, and what legal protections govern the situation.

But there is another question we should ask as well:

Was the response proportionate to what actually happened?

A private institution may have the authority to discipline someone. That does not necessarily mean every possible punishment is equally reasonable. A company may have the authority to terminate an

employee under certain circumstances, but that does not prevent people from debating whether the termination was justified. A university may have authority to establish standards for invited speakers, but that does not mean every application of those standards deserves automatic approval.

Authority answers one question.

It does not answer every question.

This is where the Right to Leave People Alone becomes useful again. The principle protects the individual's freedom from unnecessary interference, but it also recognizes that other people and institutions have their own freedoms. We cannot simply demand that every private organization remain neutral, employ everyone, publish everything, host every speaker, or associate with every person.

That would replace one form of control with another.

The difficult task is recognizing the competing freedoms without pretending that they always point in the same direction.

A speaker may want access to an audience. A university may want control over its events. An employee may want freedom to express political opinions. An employer may want control over its workplace. A writer may want publication.

A publisher may want editorial independence. A consumer may want a company to change its behavior. The company may want the freedom to determine its own policies.

All of those interests can exist simultaneously. They will not always be compatible.

That is why the private sphere requires judgment rather than a simple rule that says either “the institution can do whatever it wants” or “the individual has a right to whatever the institution controls.” Neither principle is adequate by itself.

And this brings us back to the central problem with the phrase “cancel culture.” If we use the phrase to describe every instance in which a private institution makes a decision that someone dislikes, we erase important distinctions. If we use it to suggest that private institutions have no meaningful power because they are not government, we make the opposite mistake.

The more useful question is always the same:

Who is exercising power, what kind of power is it, and what rules govern its use? Sometimes the answer will be government. Sometimes it will be a corporation. Sometimes it will be a university. Sometimes it will be a media organization. Sometimes it will be millions of individual consumers.

And sometimes it will be some combination of all of them. The constitutional question may change depending on the answer. The civic question does not disappear.

We still have to decide what kind of society we want to build around that power, what limits should exist, what responsibilities institutions should recognize, and how we respond when institutions exercise authority in ways we believe are wrong.

That is why private power cannot simply be dismissed as “not censorship.” It can be different from government censorship and still matter enormously. And that realization leads to the next uncomfortable part of the argument: you are not powerless in this system either.

And That Means You Have Power Too

This is the part of cancel culture that is easiest to forget: **you are not powerless.** You do not need the government to agree with you before you can exercise political influence. You can write, organize, protest, boycott, donate, volunteer, publish, persuade, or simply refuse to participate. You can decide where your money goes, which organizations receive your support, which candidates receive your vote, which publications you read, which businesses you patronize, and which causes you are willing to spend your time defending. The American tradition has repeatedly demonstrated the enormous power of ordinary citizens acting collectively.

That power is one of the reasons political movements have historically been able to challenge institutions that appeared much more powerful than the individuals opposing them. A single consumer may have very little influence over a corporation. A single employee may have very little influence over an employer. A single citizen may have very little influence over a politician. But people can organize around a common purpose, combine their resources, and make their disagreement difficult to ignore. Political power does not belong exclusively to people who hold office or command large institutions; ordinary citizens can exercise it through the choices they make and the collective action they organize.

That is not necessarily something we should fear. It is something we should understand.

The history we have examined throughout this article is filled with examples of ordinary people discovering that they possessed more power than they initially realized. Colonists used economic pressure against British goods. Abolitionists organized consumers around the rejection of slave-produced products. Civil Rights activists used boycotts and demonstrations to pressure businesses and governments. Labor movements organized workers around their shared economic interests. Suffragists organized, protested, published, lobbied, and demanded political change. Modern Americans continue to use many of the same basic tools, even though the technology through which they organize has changed dramatically.

The underlying principle has remained remarkably consistent: **people can exercise political power without holding political office.** That matters because it changes how we should think about cancel culture. If political power exists only inside government, then the person who does not control government appears almost powerless, and their only meaningful option would be to convince someone in authority to act on their behalf. But that has never been the American political tradition. Citizens have always had other ways to exert influence.

You can refuse to buy something. You can refuse to attend. You can refuse to donate or subscribe. You can refuse to work for an organization. You can encourage other people to make the same choices. You can organize a protest, publish an argument, create a competing institution, campaign against a

politician, or vote. These are all forms of power, even though they operate in very different ways and carry very different consequences.

Some of that power is individual. Some is collective. Some is economic, some social, and some directly political. Some operates through persuasion, while other forms operate through the consequences of people voluntarily changing their behavior. They do not all carry the same risks, and they do not all raise the same questions about rights, but they share something important: **they give citizens ways to act without first obtaining permission from the government.**

That is an important feature of a free society, but it is also where the argument becomes uncomfortable. If you have the freedom to organize against a company, another person has the freedom to organize against a company you support. If you have the freedom to boycott a business because of its political conduct, someone else has the freedom to boycott a business because of political conduct you support. If you can encourage advertisers to withdraw their money from a program, other people can encourage advertisers to withdraw their money from a program you like.

The same freedom that gives you power gives your opponents power.

We tend to experience our own political pressure from the inside. We see the reasons behind it. We know the injustice we believe we are responding to. We see the people we are trying to help, understand the demands we are making, and believe that the principles behind our actions justify the pressure we are applying. The person on the receiving end experiences something very different. They see the customers who are leaving, the advertisers withdrawing, the employer receiving demands, the social-media campaign gathering momentum, and the consequences arriving.

They may believe the campaign against them is completely unjust. That does not automatically mean they are right, but it does mean that the exercise of private power should not become invisible simply because the people exercising it believe their cause is justified. If we are going to take private power seriously when it is used against us, we also have to take it seriously when we are the ones using it against someone else.

This is where the Right to Leave People Alone and the freedom to exercise political influence come into tension. You have the right to decide what you will support. You also have the right to try to persuade other people to make different choices. But the people you are trying to persuade retain their own freedom to say no. Your ability to influence someone does not automatically give you authority over the decision they ultimately make.

That distinction becomes especially important when a campaign grows large. A single person deciding not to buy something is exercising individual choice. Ten thousand people independently making the same decision can create enormous economic pressure. A political organization can coordinate those people and give the campaign a common message, while social media can accelerate the process dramatically by allowing information, accusations, demands, and calls for action to reach enormous audiences almost instantly.

The scale can change without necessarily changing the underlying mechanism. A million people choosing to withdraw their support can have extraordinary consequences without any one of those people possessing the authority to force everyone else to do the same. The campaign may be

enormously effective precisely because so many people voluntarily participate. That is an important distinction between power and coercion.

Power does not automatically mean force. A consumer has power because they can choose where to spend their money. A voter has power because they can choose whom to support. A worker has power because workers can organize. A journalist has power because information can influence public opinion. A citizen has power because citizens can persuade, organize, protest, and participate in political institutions. A free society does not eliminate these forms of power; it distributes them among millions of people and countless institutions.

That distribution can be messy. It can produce outcomes we consider unfair. It can allow movements we strongly oppose to become influential. It can allow businesses we dislike to succeed and businesses we support to fail. It can allow people with opinions we find offensive to build audiences and people with opinions we admire to lose them. None of those outcomes automatically demonstrates that the system has failed. They are among the consequences of giving individuals and groups meaningful freedom to make choices and organize around them.

The danger comes when we begin believing that our opponents' possession of that same freedom is itself a problem. If I believe consumers should be free to boycott a company, then I have to recognize that the company's supporters may organize a counter-boycott. If I believe employees should be free to organize against an employer, I have to recognize that employers possess their own lawful rights and responsibilities. If I believe activists should be free to pressure a university, I have to recognize that another group of activists can pressure the same university in the opposite direction.

The existence of competing pressure does not necessarily mean the system has failed. It may mean that a pluralistic society is functioning through competing interests rather than through a single authority deciding which side is allowed to prevail. The point of protecting voluntary political participation is not to guarantee that everyone will get the outcome they want. It is to preserve the ability of people to participate in the argument.

Of course, there are limits. Citizens cannot use threats or violence simply because they believe their cause is important. They cannot stalk people, assault them, unlawfully discriminate against them, or use coercion as a substitute for persuasion. Private pressure does not become legitimate merely because it is private. The fact that an action occurs outside government does not eliminate the need to ask whether someone's rights have been violated or whether unlawful conduct has occurred.

But the existence of those limits should not cause us to overlook the enormous amount of legitimate political activity that exists between doing nothing and using force. Most political pressure exists in that space. Citizens argue, persuade, organize, protest, boycott, donate, withdraw support, and attempt to convince other people to do the same. Those activities can be disruptive and sometimes extremely effective, but they are also among the ordinary tools through which people without formal political authority attempt to change their society.

That is why citizens should understand the power they already possess. If you believe a company is behaving irresponsibly, you do not necessarily need the government to order the company to change. You can stop buying from it, explain why, and encourage others to do the same. If you believe a

politician is wrong, you do not need the government to silence that politician. You can argue against them, campaign against them, organize voters, support an opponent, and try to persuade the public that another choice would be better.

If you believe a publication is spreading information you consider false, you can criticize it, publish a response, choose another source, or encourage other readers to examine the evidence for themselves. If you believe an institution is acting improperly, you can organize around the issue and attempt to persuade others to demand change. You have tools available to you that do not require government intervention, and the American political tradition has repeatedly demonstrated that those tools can be powerful.

So the danger in cancel culture is not simply that people have discovered how to pressure one another. Americans have always known how to do that. The more important question is whether we understand the power we are exercising well enough to use it without abandoning the principles we claim to defend.

Political pressure can expose wrongdoing. It can force powerful institutions to confront problems they would rather ignore. It can give ordinary people a voice when they otherwise have very little institutional power. It can also become disproportionate, vindictive, based on false information, or directed toward making participation itself impossible. The existence of these possibilities is precisely why we have to examine the mechanism rather than automatically celebrating or condemning the outcome.

The tool is not automatically good or bad simply because we happen to agree with the cause behind it. The way we use it matters, the information on which we rely matters, the consequences we seek matter, and the freedom we leave to other people matters. That is where the principle of leaving people alone meets the reality of political participation: we need enough freedom to act, but also enough restraint to recognize that other people possess freedom too.

And that brings us back to the mirror.

If we believe ordinary citizens should have the power to pressure institutions, we have to accept that our political opponents are ordinary citizens too. If we believe people should be free to organize, we cannot reserve that freedom for organizations we consider morally worthy. If we believe consumers should be able to make political choices with their wallets, we have to recognize that other consumers may make choices we strongly dislike.

That does not mean surrendering our beliefs. It means recognizing the reciprocal nature of freedom. The power belongs to you, but it also belongs to the person you disagree with. A principle that protects only our own ability to act is not really a principle of liberty; it is simply a description of the power we would like to possess.

The harder question is whether we are willing to recognize that power when someone else uses it. That is where the Consistency Test becomes unavoidable.

The Consistency Test Returns

We have now reached the point where the argument has to turn back toward us. It is relatively easy to identify a principle when it protects something we already believe in. It is much harder when the same principle protects someone we strongly disagree with. That is why the Consistency Test matters: it asks us to take political identity out of the equation long enough to determine whether we actually believe in the rule we are claiming to defend.

If you believe a company should be free to respond to political pressure when that pressure serves your cause, ask whether you believe the same thing when the political pressure comes from people you oppose. If you believe consumers should boycott businesses over political conduct, ask whether you still believe in that right when the boycott hurts a company you support. If you believe a private institution should be able to establish standards for its employees or participants, ask whether you still believe that when the institution's standards produce an outcome you find offensive. The circumstances of each case may be different, and those differences can matter, but the underlying principle should not change simply because we dislike the people involved.

The same test applies to government power. If you believe political speech should be protected from government interference, ask whether you are willing to defend that principle for speech that makes you furious. If you believe government should have the authority to restrict certain conduct, ask whether you would accept that authority if the people controlling the government were your political opponents. If you believe extraordinary government action is justified because the country faces a serious threat, ask whether you would still accept the same power if someone you deeply distrusts were the person deciding what constitutes that threat.

This is where consistency becomes difficult, because we tend to experience political power differently depending upon who is using it. When people we agree with exercise power, we are more likely to see the purpose behind it and understand the problem they believe they are solving. We may describe their actions as necessary, protective, responsible, or even courageous. When people we oppose exercise the same power, we are more likely to see the risks, the abuses, and the consequences. The power itself may not have changed, but our description of it often does.

That does not mean every situation is identical or that every action deserves the same judgment. Facts matter. Circumstances matter. The rights involved matter. The legal authority involved matters. Proportionality matters. The Consistency Test is not an argument that every dispute must produce the same outcome; it is an argument that the principle used to reach the outcome should be capable of surviving a change in political identity.

That distinction is important because otherwise we can confuse principles with preferences. A preference says, “I want my side to have this power.” A principle says, “I believe this power should exist or should be limited regardless of who controls it.” Those are very different things. A preference is easy to hold when your side is winning because it tells you what you want right now. A principle becomes more valuable when political circumstances change because it gives you a standard that does not depend upon who happens to be in control, even when that standard produces an answer you dislike.

Consider a boycott. Suppose you support a boycott against a company because you believe its political conduct is unacceptable. You may consider the boycott principled and justified. Now imagine that people with the opposite political beliefs organize a boycott against a company you support. The underlying facts may be different, and those differences should be examined, but if your response is automatically that their boycott is illegitimate simply because you disagree with their cause, then you are no longer defending the principle of consumer choice. You are defending your preferred outcome. The Consistency Test does not require you to support every boycott; it requires you to explain why the principle applies differently rather than simply assuming that your side's motives are legitimate and the other side's are not.

The same problem appears with private institutions. You may believe an employer should have the right to establish standards for its employees, but what happens when those standards produce a result you consider politically offensive? If you believe a university should have authority to determine whom it invites to speak, what happens when the university excludes someone whose ideas you support? If you believe a media organization has editorial independence, what happens when it makes an editorial decision that you believe is irresponsible or biased? You remain free to criticize those decisions, organize against them, or withdraw your support, but the question is whether you still recognize the institution's underlying authority when you dislike the result.

Freedom does not guarantee that every exercise of freedom will produce an outcome we approve of. A newspaper's editorial independence means it can publish things we dislike. A private organization's freedom of association means it may choose associations we dislike. Consumer freedom means people can spend money on businesses we would rather see fail. If we defend those freedoms only when they produce outcomes we like, then what we really support is not freedom itself but favorable outcomes.

The government version of the test is even more demanding because government power is more difficult to take back once it has been established. The emergency measure you support today may become the weapon your political opponents control tomorrow. The precedent you establish against one group does not remain permanently attached to that group; once a government has exercised a power, future governments inherit the possibility of exercising it. That is why the question cannot simply be whether a particular government power helps us right now. We also have to ask whether we would accept that same authority if the other side controlled it.

That question does not automatically tell us whether a particular government action is constitutional. Constitutional questions require legal analysis and attention to the facts. It does, however, tell us something important about our own political reasoning. If we support a government power only because we trust the people currently exercising it, then our confidence may be personal rather than institutional. A constitutional principle that protects only the people we trust is not much of a protection when the people we do not trust eventually acquire the same authority.

The history of Richard Nixon makes this distinction especially clear. The concern surrounding Nixon's treatment of political opponents was not simply that a president disliked his critics; presidents are entitled to dislike criticism. The deeper concern was the use or attempted use of governmental authority against perceived political enemies. The historical lesson is not that one party owns the problem of

government abuse. It is that political power changes hands, and powers created or expanded for one political purpose can later be used by people pursuing very different purposes.

That lesson does not require us to treat every modern controversy as equivalent to Watergate. It requires us to understand the mechanism. If a private citizen criticizes a politician, that is one form of political participation. If a group organizes a boycott, that is another. If a government official uses legal or regulatory authority to punish protected political expression, the nature of the power involved is different. The Consistency Test requires us to pay attention to that difference regardless of whether the people exercising the power are our allies or our opponents.[U.S. Senate: Watergate] Source: U.S. Senate Historical Office: Watergate

The same principle applies to political violence. If we condemn political violence when it is directed at people we support but excuse or minimize it when the victims belong to the other political side, then we are not really defending a principle against political violence. We are defending our side from political violence. An attack does not become more legitimate because the victim holds beliefs we despise, and a threat does not become less serious because it is directed at someone we believe deserves criticism. A person does not become less deserving of basic legal protection because we disagree with their politics.

The same is true of speech. If we believe people have a right to express political opinions, that right will sometimes protect opinions we consider offensive. If we believe peaceful protest is legitimate, protesters will sometimes challenge institutions or causes we support. If we believe consumers should be free to make economic choices based on their values, those choices will sometimes damage businesses we like. Those are not failures of the principles; they are consequences of having principles that apply beyond our own political preferences.

This is where labels such as “cancel culture,” “accountability,” “censorship,” “activism,” and even “free speech” can become obstacles rather than explanations. The same event may be described as accountability by one side and cancellation by the other. A boycott may be described as consumer activism by its organizers and economic intimidation by its target. A private institution's decision may be described as responsible standards by its supporters and ideological exclusion by its critics. Those competing descriptions may reflect genuinely different interpretations of the same conduct, but the label itself does not settle the question.

We still have to ask what happened, what right is involved, who exercised the power, what authority they possessed, what consequence was sought, and what alternatives were available. Those questions take longer to answer than a political label, but they are much more likely to tell us what actually happened. They also make it harder for us to reach a conclusion simply because we have already decided which political side we want to defend.

None of this requires moral relativism or intellectual surrender. Consistency does not mean pretending that every side is equally correct, that every accusation deserves equal weight, or that every protest is equally legitimate. It does not require us to abandon judgment or to treat every political conflict as morally symmetrical. It requires us to accept that our principles may sometimes produce an answer we do not like, particularly when the people benefiting from those principles are people whose politics we oppose.

If we defend free expression, there will be times when that freedom protects speech we consider offensive. If we defend peaceful protest, there will be times when protesters challenge institutions or causes we support. If we defend limits on government authority, there will be times when those limits prevent the government from doing something we personally believe would produce a desirable result. If we defend the right of citizens to use economic pressure, there will be times when that pressure is directed toward a company or organization we support.

That is the price of having principles instead of preferences. A preference protects what we want; a principle places a limit on what we are willing to do even when doing more would benefit us. A preference asks whether a particular action helps our side. A principle asks whether the same rule should apply when the political circumstances are reversed. The first can change with the political winds. The second gives us something more durable to stand on when those winds change.

That is why the Consistency Test is not really about our opponents. It is about us. Before demanding that someone be silenced, removed, fired, boycotted, prosecuted, or excluded, we should know what they actually did, what rights are involved, who possesses the authority to act, and what consequence we are asking for. Then we should turn the situation around and ask whether we would defend the same standard if the person involved were our political ally and the people demanding action were our political opponents.

The question is not whether we would still dislike the person or disagree with what they did. We probably would. The question is whether we would still believe the same rule should apply, and whether we would defend the same mechanism if the political identities were reversed. If the answer changes solely because the people involved have changed sides, then we should at least recognize that we may be defending a preference rather than a principle.

That is the uncomfortable part of the Consistency Test. It does not ask us merely whether we can recognize hypocrisy in other people; it asks whether we are willing to recognize it in ourselves. And that matters because the principles that protect us when we are unpopular are often the same principles that protect people we would rather not defend.

If we want those principles to mean something, they have to survive that test.

Where Leaving People Alone Ends

None of this means society has to tolerate everything. The Right to Leave People Alone has always contained a boundary, because individual liberty exists alongside the rights of other people. A person's freedom to act does not include a general license to threaten another person, assault them, defraud them, discriminate unlawfully against them, or prevent them from exercising their own rights. If we forget that boundary, the principle of individual liberty can be turned into an excuse for one person to impose serious harm on another.

That is why “leave people alone” cannot mean leaving everyone completely untouched regardless of what they do. A free society necessarily places limits on individual behavior when that behavior crosses into genuine violations of another person's rights. We prohibit violence because the victim has a right to

bodily security. We prohibit fraud because people have a right not to be deliberately deceived out of their property. We prohibit certain forms of unlawful discrimination because the law recognizes circumstances in which individuals cannot be denied particular rights or opportunities on prohibited grounds. We restrict conduct that prevents other people from exercising their own rights because liberty cannot logically include the power to destroy someone else's liberty.

The difficult part is identifying where that boundary actually is.

That is considerably harder than simply saying that everyone should be left alone. Almost any political argument can be framed as an argument about harm, and almost any political movement can describe its opponents as dangerous. A person can claim that a protest is harmful because it disrupts ordinary life. A business can claim that criticism harms its reputation. A political movement can argue that an opposing ideology threatens the country. A citizen can claim that another person's speech causes harm simply because the speech is offensive. Those claims may sometimes identify genuine problems, but the existence of a claimed harm does not automatically establish the right to use coercive power in response.

This is where the distinction between offense and injury becomes important. Being offended by another person's beliefs is not necessarily the same thing as having your rights violated. Being angry about another person's political position is not necessarily the same thing as being threatened by that person. Disliking a company's decision is not necessarily the same thing as being entitled to government intervention against the company. If every experience of anger, discomfort, disagreement, or offense were treated as sufficient justification for controlling another person's conduct, the principle of leaving people alone would disappear almost immediately.

That does not mean emotional or social consequences are meaningless. Words can matter. Public criticism can matter. Reputation can matter. Some speech can contribute to real-world harm, and some conduct that begins as political disagreement can cross into threats, harassment, intimidation, or other unlawful behavior. The point is not to pretend that everything short of physical violence is harmless. The point is to distinguish among different kinds of harm rather than treating every undesirable consequence as though it were the same kind of rights violation.

The distinction matters particularly in the context of cancel culture. Someone can say something offensive, and other people can decide that they no longer want to associate with that person. They can criticize the statement, stop buying the person's work, encourage others to do the same, or ask an organization to reconsider its relationship with the person. Those actions can produce serious personal or economic consequences, but the fact that the consequences are serious does not by itself tell us whether the response is legitimate or illegitimate. We still have to examine the mechanism, the authority involved, the nature of the conduct, and the consequence being demanded.

That is why the questions we have been asking throughout this article remain useful here. Before interfering with another person's life, what exactly are you trying to prevent? What right are you protecting? What authority are you using? Is the response proportional to the conduct? Could persuasion accomplish the same objective without coercion? And is the proposed response actually connected to the conduct that prompted it, or has the punishment expanded beyond the original dispute?

That last question deserves particular attention because consequences can spread far beyond the original conduct. Someone may make a controversial statement at a political rally, and the controversy may follow them into their workplace, their professional associations, their personal relationships, and their online life. Sometimes those consequences arise because people independently make choices about whom they want to support or associate with. Sometimes they arise because organizations believe the conduct violates legitimate standards. But there can also be circumstances in which the objective becomes less about responding to the original conduct and more about making the person unable to participate anywhere else.

That is where the Right to Leave People Alone begins to intersect with the question of power. If I decide that I no longer want to listen to you, I have exercised a boundary around my own participation. If I try to prevent everyone else from listening to you, I have moved beyond my own boundary and begun attempting to control theirs. If I ask an organization not to employ you, that organization must decide what authority and responsibility it has under its own rules and applicable law. If I demand that the government punish you for protected expression, the constitutional question changes again.

The same underlying disagreement can therefore produce very different questions depending upon what we are actually asking another person or institution to do.

This is why the principle cannot simply be “never interfere.” There are legitimate reasons to intervene. Parents intervene when children are in danger. People intervene when someone is being assaulted. Governments enforce laws when citizens violate the rights of others. Institutions establish rules so that their members can participate under agreed conditions. Citizens organize collectively because individual action is sometimes insufficient to accomplish a political objective.

The principle is instead a presumption of restraint.

Before we exercise power over another person, we should be able to explain why that power is justified.

That presumption matters because power tends to expand when there is no clear reason to stop it. If being offended justifies punishment, then increasingly severe forms of offense can justify increasingly severe punishment. If disagreement is treated as evidence of danger, then more and more disagreement can eventually be classified as dangerous. If protecting people from harmful ideas becomes sufficient justification for suppressing political expression, then the definition of “harmful” becomes enormously important—and potentially subject to whoever happens to possess the authority to decide.

The history examined throughout this article gives us plenty of reason to be cautious about that progression. Americans have repeatedly confronted circumstances in which existing institutions defended restrictions as necessary for order, security, morality, public safety, or the protection of other people. Sometimes government intervention was necessary to protect rights. At other times, claims of necessity were used to justify restrictions that Americans later came to regard as unjust. The historical lesson is not that government should never act. It is that the justification for government action matters, and that the power being exercised should be examined rather than accepted simply because the stated purpose sounds worthy.

The same caution applies outside government.

Private citizens and organizations can exercise enormous power without possessing governmental authority. A large employer can affect someone's livelihood. A university can affect someone's education or career. A media organization can affect someone's public reputation. A major online platform can affect someone's ability to communicate with an audience. Consumers acting collectively can affect whether a business survives. None of that automatically makes private power illegitimate, but it does mean that “private” cannot be treated as the end of the conversation.

The question remains: What are you asking this power to do?

Are you asking someone to listen to you? Are you asking people to withdraw their voluntary support? Are you asking an institution to enforce its own rules? Are you asking an employer to make an employment decision? Are you asking a private platform to enforce its terms of service? Are you asking the government to impose a legal consequence? Or are you trying to make it impossible for another person to participate in public life at all?

Those are different requests, involving different forms of power and different standards of justification.

The Right to Leave People Alone therefore does not tell us that every person should be immune from criticism, consequences, disagreement, or accountability. It tells us where our reasoning should begin. The fact that another person has done something we dislike does not automatically give us a claim over their life. Before we cross that boundary, we should be able to identify the right we are protecting, the harm we are preventing, and the authority we believe justifies our intervention.

And then there is the Consistency Test.

Would we accept the same intervention if the political identities were reversed? Would we still consider the conduct serious if the person involved belonged to our political side? Would we still defend the same government authority if our opponents controlled it? Would we still believe the same private institution had the right to make the same decision if the decision affected someone whose politics we supported?

Those questions do not solve every dispute. They do something more valuable: they make us think before we reach for power. They force us to distinguish between protecting a right and protecting ourselves from disagreement, between preventing genuine harm and preventing discomfort, and between exercising our own freedom and attempting to control someone else's.

That distinction is where leaving people alone ends—and where the difficult work of deciding when intervention is justified begins.

The Neighbor Is Still There

At the beginning of this section, we imagined the person next door whose political beliefs you cannot stand. The hypothetical becomes more interesting when we remember that you are also their neighbor. They have to live with you too. You may be the person whose political sign they hate, the person whose opinions they consider dangerous, or the person whose politics they believe are destroying the country.

They may believe your religious beliefs are wrong, your economic ideas are foolish, or your understanding of American history is completely mistaken.

And yet you still share the same country.

That fact sounds ordinary because it is ordinary. Millions of Americans live, work, worship, shop, vote, raise families, and participate in communities alongside people whose political beliefs they find deeply objectionable. They do not necessarily resolve those disagreements. They do not necessarily become friends. In many cases, they may never have a meaningful conversation about politics at all. They simply continue occupying the same political and social space.

That is the part we keep coming back to.

The goal of a free society cannot be to make sure your neighbor thinks like you, and it cannot even be to make sure your neighbor likes you. The more realistic—and more demanding—goal is to establish enough boundaries that both of you can remain free while neither of you violates the other's rights. That requires something more difficult than agreement. It requires accepting that another person can possess the same basic freedoms you claim for yourself while using those freedoms in ways you strongly dislike.

This is where the idea of the neighbor becomes more useful than an abstract discussion about political factions. It is easy to say that people on the other side of the country should have freedom. It becomes harder when the person exercising that freedom lives next door. The political argument becomes personal. You know what they believe, you may know how they vote, you may see the political sign in their yard, and you may hear them express opinions that you consider foolish, offensive, or even morally wrong. The temptation is to think that because you believe their ideas are harmful, you therefore have some greater claim over what they are permitted to do.

But what exactly would that claim be?

You have your own political rights. You can vote, organize, persuade, protest, publish, campaign, donate, boycott, criticize, and encourage other people to reject ideas you believe are wrong. You can decide what you watch, what you purchase, which organizations you support, and with whom you associate, subject to applicable law. You can make a forceful argument that your neighbor's political position is dangerous and should be defeated at the ballot box or in the broader marketplace of ideas.

Your neighbor possesses those same basic opportunities.

That reciprocity is easy to forget when we are convinced that our own position is correct. We tend to think of our political activity as participation and theirs as interference. Our boycott is principled; theirs is vindictive. Our protest is necessary; theirs is disruptive. Our criticism is accountability; theirs is harassment. Our demand that an institution respond is legitimate; their demand that an institution respond is an attack. Sometimes those distinctions may be justified by the actual facts, but they cannot be justified merely by the identity of the people involved.

That is why the neighbor remains important.

Imagine that your neighbor supports a political candidate you believe would be disastrous for the country. You do not have to remain silent. You can put up your own sign, knock on doors, distribute

literature, donate to the opposing campaign, write an argument, or persuade other voters. You can try to convince your neighbor that they are wrong. You can even decide that you would rather not associate with them socially because their politics are incompatible with your own values.

But none of those choices requires you to conclude that your neighbor has forfeited the right to participate in the political community.

The same is true when the disagreement becomes more personal. Perhaps your neighbor belongs to a religious organization whose beliefs you reject. Perhaps they support a position on abortion, guns, immigration, taxation, race, or foreign policy that you consider deeply immoral. Perhaps they believe something about American history that you consider demonstrably false. You may challenge those beliefs. You may organize against the political consequences of those beliefs. You may attempt to persuade others not to support them.

You do not have to pretend that the disagreement does not matter.

That is an important qualification because leaving someone alone is not the same thing as approving of them. Restraint is not surrender. Refusing to interfere with another person's lawful choices does not require you to stop arguing that those choices are wrong, harmful, misguided, or politically dangerous. A person can defend individual liberty while passionately opposing another person's political philosophy.

In fact, that may be where the principle is most meaningful.

If we only believe in leaving people alone when we like what they are doing, then we are not really defending a principle of liberty. We are simply defending our preferences. The person who agrees with us does not require much tolerance. The real test comes when someone exercises a freedom we wish they would not exercise and we nevertheless recognize that the freedom belongs to them.

That does not mean every exercise of freedom is protected from consequences. If the neighbor threatens you, assaults you, steals from you, or attempts to prevent you from exercising your own rights, the situation is different. The existence of disagreement does not create immunity from legitimate consequences for conduct that violates another person's rights. But that distinction is precisely why we have to separate disagreement from conduct, offense from injury, and political opposition from an actual violation of someone's rights.

And that brings us back to the basic reality of living together.

You may believe your neighbor is wrong about nearly everything. Your neighbor may believe exactly the same thing about you. You may each consider the other's politics dangerous. You may each believe that the other side misunderstands America, threatens important values, or is moving the country in the wrong direction. Neither of you has to surrender those beliefs simply because you share a community.

Sometimes that means arguing. Sometimes it means organizing, voting, or walking away. Sometimes it means accepting something Americans have always found difficult: you can be completely convinced that your neighbor is wrong and still leave your neighbor alone.

The question is where that principle stops.

And that is where we need to draw the line.

The Line

We have spent this entire article examining different kinds of pressure: persuasion, protest, boycotts, public criticism, social pressure, institutional decisions, economic consequences, government power, and, ultimately, violence. Those things can all produce consequences for the people on the receiving end, but they are not the same thing. The difficult part is determining where legitimate disagreement and collective action end and an unjustified attempt to control another person's rights begins. That line matters because freedom is not simply the absence of consequences; if you speak publicly, other people are free to criticize you, and if you run a business, customers are free to stop buying from you. A free society necessarily contains friction because freedom gives people the ability to respond to one another.

The mistake is to assume that every form of pressure belongs in the same category simply because the person experiencing it describes the result in the same way. A person who loses customers may say they were canceled. A person who loses a job may say they were canceled. A person whose speech is removed from a private platform may say they were canceled. A person who is threatened by a mob may say they were canceled. Those experiences may all be deeply consequential, but the mechanisms producing them are different, and those differences matter.

So rather than asking only whether someone was “canceled,” we should ask what happened, who acted, what power they possessed, what they were trying to accomplish, and what consequence they were seeking. The further we move from disagreement toward coercion, government action, and violence, the more important those questions become. There is no single rule that resolves every case, but there are meaningful boundaries that allow us to distinguish one form of political conflict from another.

The First Line: Disagreement

The first line is the easiest to identify because it is the foundation of political life. You say something I disagree with, and I tell you that I think you are wrong. I write an article explaining why, you write one explaining why I am wrong, and perhaps neither of us changes our mind. We may become angry with each other. We may consider each other's arguments foolish or even morally offensive. None of that, by itself, means that something has gone wrong.

It is the ordinary condition of a free society.

Americans have argued passionately throughout their history over questions that mattered enormously to them. The abolitionists believed slavery was morally indefensible, while their opponents defended the institution and the social and constitutional order surrounding it. Suffragists believed women deserved political equality, while their opponents defended traditional political arrangements. Civil Rights activists challenged segregation while segregationists defended it. The existence of strong moral conviction did not make those disagreements illegitimate; in many cases, that conviction was exactly what forced the country to confront questions it had previously avoided.

That point is worth emphasizing because political disagreement is sometimes treated as though it were itself a form of harm. If someone tells us that our beliefs are wrong, we may experience the statement as an attack rather than as an argument. But a political system that protects freedom has to leave room for people to be wrong about one another, to argue about what is true, and to attempt to persuade one another without requiring agreement as the price of continued participation.

The first line, then, is not a line between people who agree and people who disagree. It is the recognition that disagreement itself remains part of political life.

The Second Line: Pressure

The next line is pressure. You disagree with me and want other people to know why, so you organize a petition, encourage people not to buy my product, protest outside an institution, ask an employer to reconsider its relationship with me, encourage voters to reject a politician, or persuade advertisers to withdraw their support from a program. This is more powerful than simply expressing disagreement because you are no longer asking only to be heard. You are attempting to influence what other people do.

That is still a normal part of political life.

The history we have examined is filled with examples. The Revolution relied upon nonimportation agreements; abolitionists encouraged consumers to purchase free-produced goods; Civil Rights activists organized boycotts; labor movements used economic pressure; suffragists organized politically; and Vietnam protesters pressured universities, businesses, and government institutions. Political pressure is not an accidental feature of democracy. It is one of the ways citizens exercise power when they believe persuasion alone is insufficient. [Library of Congress: colonial boycotts and nonimportation] [Library of Congress: Free Produce Movement terminology] [U.S. State Department: Articles of Association]

The word “pressure,” however, should not automatically be treated as a synonym for coercion. Every political campaign applies pressure in some sense. A campaign advertisement pressures voters to reconsider their choice. A boycott pressures a company to reconsider a policy. A petition pressures an institution to respond. A protest pressures government officials to pay attention. The important question is not whether pressure exists, but what form it takes and what the person applying it is asking others to do.

That distinction becomes especially important because political pressure can be exercised voluntarily. I can decide not to buy your product. I can ask other people not to buy it. They can decide for themselves whether to join me. I can campaign against your political position, and voters can decide whether my argument persuades them. Political pressure becomes more complicated when the objective shifts from influencing someone's voluntary choices to depriving them of the ability to make choices themselves.

The Third Line: Consequences

Pressure can produce consequences even when nobody formally orders them. A company may lose customers and change its policy. An organization may decide that a controversial speaker no longer fits its mission. An employer may determine that an employee's conduct violates workplace rules. A

musician may lose professional opportunities after making a political statement, while a public figure may discover that people no longer want to support them.

These consequences can feel like punishment to the person experiencing them, but that does not automatically make them illegitimate. Sometimes there are genuine professional or institutional reasons for a decision; sometimes the decision is controversial; sometimes the public campaign surrounding it is based on incomplete or false information; and sometimes the consequences may be disproportionate to the conduct. We therefore cannot determine the legitimacy of a consequence simply by observing that somebody suffered one.

We have to examine the mechanism.

Who made the decision? What authority did they possess? What rules governed the decision? Was the consequence connected to the conduct that produced it? Was the decision voluntary, or was someone threatened into making it? Was government authority involved? Were other people's legal rights implicated? Those questions may not produce an answer that everyone accepts, but they allow us to discuss the actual dispute rather than simply attaching a label to the outcome.

This distinction is particularly important in an article about cancel culture because the word “cancelled” often describes the destination without telling us how the person got there. A person can lose an audience because people voluntarily stopped supporting them. A person can lose employment because an employer made a decision under its own policies and applicable law. A company can lose customers because consumers organized a boycott. A person can face government action through an entirely different mechanism. The consequences may look similar from the outside, but the underlying questions are not.

The Fourth Line: Coercion

Coercion changes the character of the interaction. There is a meaningful difference between telling someone, “I will not buy your product,” and telling them, “You will change your position or something terrible will happen to you.” The first uses the speaker's own freedom of choice; the second attempts to deprive the other person of meaningful freedom through a threat. The difference is not simply the intensity of the political disagreement. It is the mechanism being used to obtain compliance.

That distinction becomes even more important when intimidation or violence is involved. A protester standing outside a building with a sign is exercising one kind of power, while a person physically preventing someone from entering that building is exercising another. A consumer campaign asking people to stop purchasing a product is one thing; threatening employees until they stop selling it is another. A political organization urging voters to defeat a candidate is one thing; physically preventing those voters from participating is something else entirely.

The cause does not determine the category. A good cause does not make coercion acceptable, and a cause we dislike does not make ordinary political pressure coercive. That is one of the places where political consistency becomes difficult, because we are often willing to describe pressure as coercion when our opponents use it and as justified activism when people on our own side use it.

The better question is what is actually being done.

Are people being persuaded, pressured, threatened, intimidated, or physically prevented from acting? Are they still capable of making their own choices? Is someone using their own economic or social power, or are they attempting to force another person through threats or unlawful conduct? These distinctions do not make every case easy, but without them the word “coercion” becomes little more than another political accusation.

The Fifth Line: Government

The most significant boundary appears when government authority enters the picture. Government possesses powers that private citizens do not: it can impose taxes, enforce criminal laws, regulate conduct, issue licenses, conduct investigations, prosecute violations, and exercise other forms of coercive authority. Because of that power, the Constitution places restrictions on what government may do, particularly when fundamental rights such as speech, religion, assembly, and political participation are involved.

That does not mean every government action affecting a person is automatically illegitimate. Government has legitimate responsibilities, including enforcing laws and protecting people from genuine violations of their rights. The important point is that government possesses a different kind of authority from the individual citizen who decides not to buy a product, the consumer who organizes a boycott, or the private institution that establishes its own policies.

That distinction matters because the same political objective can look very different depending upon who is pursuing it. A citizen can campaign against a politician. A group can organize a protest. Consumers can pressure a company. A private institution can make decisions within its lawful authority. But when government uses its legal power to punish or restrict someone because of protected political expression, the constitutional analysis is fundamentally different.

This is also why the phrase “censorship” has to be used carefully. Not every unpopular consequence is government censorship, and not every government restriction is necessarily unconstitutional. The relevant questions are who acted, what authority they exercised, what conduct was involved, what legal rules apply, and what rights are implicated. Calling everything “censorship” can obscure those questions just as surely as insisting that nothing can be censorship unless it looks exactly like an old-fashioned government ban.

Government power therefore represents a separate line because the state is not simply another participant in the political argument. It has coercive authority backed by law, and constitutional limits exist precisely because that authority can affect the rights and freedoms of citizens in ways that private disagreement cannot.

The Sixth Line: Violence

There is an even clearer boundary when political disagreement becomes physical violence. A person can be offended by a political argument without being physically harmed, just as a person can be criticized without being attacked. A business can lose customers without its employees being threatened, and a politician can lose an election without becoming an enemy who must be physically eliminated. Violence destroys the basic assumption underlying democratic disagreement: that people can compete for political power without physically destroying one another.

This is why political violence deserves particular attention even though it is not the same phenomenon as cancel culture. The connection is not that every boycott, criticism, or institutional decision somehow leads toward violence. Most do not. The connection is that all of these forms of political conflict raise a related underlying question about how far we are willing to go to defeat people whose ideas we oppose.

That question has taken us through a series of increasingly serious forms of political power. We began with disagreement, where one person says that another person is wrong. We moved to pressure, where people attempt to persuade others to change their behavior; to consequences, where those efforts produce real effects; to coercion, where the ability to choose begins to be threatened; to government, where the power of the state enters the equation; and finally to violence, where political conflict abandons the assumption that opponents can continue participating without being physically harmed.

But these lines should not be understood as steps on a staircase. Most disagreement never reaches the later stages. People argue and remain neighbors. They criticize one another and continue going to work. They organize opposing political movements and then vote. They boycott companies, defend companies, protest institutions, challenge government policies, lose elections, win elections, and continue living in the same country. The existence of conflict does not mean that a society is inevitably moving toward coercion or violence.

That distinction matters because we should not turn every political controversy into an existential crisis. If every disagreement is described as dangerous, every opponent becomes a threat, and every political loss becomes an emergency, then the language of genuine danger begins to lose its meaning. A free society requires citizens to recognize that some conflicts are serious without treating every conflict as justification for extraordinary action. At the same time, refusing to exaggerate political disagreements does not mean pretending that every form of conflict is harmless.

There are real differences between being offended and being threatened, between being criticized and being physically attacked, and between losing voluntary support and being forcibly prevented from exercising a right. The challenge is to recognize those differences without allowing our own political sympathies to determine where we believe the boundaries should be. A principle that only applies when our opponents are the ones exercising power is not much of a principle at all.

That brings us back to the question that has been running underneath this entire section: what exactly are we trying to protect? When we criticize someone, what are we protecting? When we organize a boycott, what are we protecting? When we demand that an institution act, what are we protecting? When we ask government to intervene, what right are we protecting? And when political conflict becomes so intense that people are willing to use violence, what has happened to the idea that Americans with profoundly different beliefs can continue to belong to the same political community?

Those questions cannot be answered simply by asking which side is right. They require us to look at the mechanism, the authority, the conduct, the rights involved, and the consequences. They require us to distinguish between opposing an idea and eliminating the person who holds it. They require us to recognize that political power can be exercised by governments, institutions, organizations, consumers, activists, and individuals, and that each form of power raises different questions.

Most importantly, they require us to remember the principle we have been examining throughout this section: another person can be profoundly wrong in our judgment without thereby losing their place within the political community. We can oppose their ideas, criticize their conduct, campaign against their political objectives, refuse to support their work, or attempt to persuade others to do the same. The existence of disagreement does not automatically give us authority over the other person's life.

That is the work of the Consistency Test. Would we accept the same rule if the political identities were reversed? Would we defend the same power if our opponents controlled it? Would we still believe the same consequence was justified if it happened to someone we supported? And would we still believe that disagreement itself was dangerous if the person expressing it happened to be on our side?

Those questions do not eliminate political conflict, and they are not supposed to. They give us a way to remain in the conflict without losing sight of the boundaries that make continued political coexistence possible. We have now examined the different forms that political pressure can take and the increasingly serious questions that arise as we move from disagreement toward coercion, government power, and violence.

The next question is harder still: what counts as harm?

That is where Part 4 begins.